

THE CRYPTO MYSTERY WEEKEND

AN INSPECTOR GRIFFIN MYSTERY



ROBERT CHESTER

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Dedication

*To Andy, with love.
You are more than everything to me.*

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The Crypto Mystery Weekend

An Inspector Griffin Mystery

Chapter One

Adam Griffin silently pulled a face at his partner, Finn Williams. They were in the middle of a phone call on speaker with their friends James and Anna. They had all become friends about six months earlier when, in a case of mistaken identity, James had been stabbed at university. Adam was the intended target, in a murder attempt by a half sister he didn't know existed.

"Come on guys. Please rescue us." James sounded desperate but also they could hear the smile in his voice. "I have to go because it's organised by some contact of my mother. Apparently I'm her first reserve for non-political functions but I could cheerfully kill her."

When they first met James his mother, Margaret Brand, was the UK Secretary of State for Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Affairs – most often known as the Foreign Secretary. Now, following a major political upheaval she'd been promoted.

"You know James, threatening to kill a major politician on an unsecured mobile phone is probably going to set off a hundred alarms at the Intelligence services" Finn laughed.

"It's OK..." James replied "I told her face to face this morning over breakfast."

"But seriously, apparently this guy is a pompous old windbag called Robert Fallon and he's exceptionally well connected." James

continued, “according to Mum he’s a mover and shaker in the church hierarchy, lots of old-school tie nonsense and port and cigars in stuffy London clubs.”

“Wow, you’re really selling it James. What do you think Anna?” Adam asked.

Anna Chubb, James’ girlfriend, had recently completed a PhD in Economics and had been scooped up as a Special Advisor to Margaret Brand – James’ mother.

“Well, part of me wants to leave James to go on his own.” There was an audible gasp from James that made Finn and Adam grin at each other.

“But let’s be honest, he shouldn’t have to face it alone. I think the four of us will have fun, and we can rescue each other from any old fogies or terminal bores”

“You never know” said James “We might even solve the murder” Finn and Adam smiled and nodded at each other.

“OK we’re in. What do you wear to a Murder Mystery Weekend?”

The event James had been so keen to promote was an exclusive, seriously up-market, Murder Mystery Weekend at an English country house hotel with at least one famous Shakespearean actor playing the lead. James hadn’t helped his cause by calling the actor ‘Sir Somebody or other’.

The hotel was in the Oxfordshire countryside surrounded by 500 acres of rolling hills. It had been built in 1850 by a wealthy textile merchant and only featured 30 luxurious rooms. It had a spa, tennis courts, a huge gym, and the grounds included a maze, two lakes and stables for horses.

It was claimed you could catch trout in the lake and have it for your dinner. The murder mystery started on the Friday afternoon and ran over an afternoon, one night and the following morning but the foursome decided to arrive on Thursday to take advantage of the facilities a little longer.

Adam immediately telephoned and booked a suite for them both. It turned out the Victoria Suite was the best in the hotel but Adam wasn't bothered by that. It was fortunate that both Adam and Finn were independently wealthy. Especially Adam.

Adam's full time job was managing the estate of his grandmother. Elspeth Potter was the author of sixty five novels, including several featuring Inspector Griffin – her most famous character. She had been encouraged to write by her very good friend and mentor, Agatha Christie. Through the 1940's 50's and 60's Elspeth Potter was one of the most successful writers in the world and there had been adapted plays, more than 40 films and a whole host of TV series. One of her books had been remade on-screen eight times since the 1940's.

Agatha Christie's greatest gift to Elspeth had been to pass on her great knowledge and enthusiasm for trust funds, offshore investment vehicles and tax planning. When Elspeth died, the day after her 100th birthday, she was virtually penniless. Adam, her sole heir and beneficiary, now controlled over £100 million in property and investments.

He was completely involved in the management of the estate, whether it was negotiating a TV series with Netflix or threatening legal action against unauthorised use of copyrighted material.

Finn and Adam had reconnected nearly a year ago. They had had a brief but enjoyable dalliance when they were sixteen but Finn's mysterious disappearance from school had stopped them becoming closer.

Finn had been acutely aware that Adam was very wealthy. He didn't really know if Adam was very wealthy, or very, very wealthy but either way it was a worry to him. Although he had never met Adam's grandmother, everybody had heard of Elspeth Potter. Finn was keen not to appear like a gold-digger so waited until they were both happy their relationship was solid before revealing that his income, from the partnership he formed, was extremely lucrative. Finn was a millionaire in his own right.

Finn had disappeared from school overnight, aged sixteen. He had been 'caught' breaking into secure systems run by MI5 and MI6, the British Intelligence services. In reality Finn had deliberately left breadcrumbs back to himself, knowing that he'd be caught.

As a result Finn was recruited by MI5 and spent five years honing his skills to the point where he was among the top five or six computer hackers in the world. Finn, if pressed, always used the word 'probably' and only claimed the top ten.

Finn was an ethical hacker, one of the so-called white-hat hackers, and he had formed a loose partnership with three others around the world to test system integrity and security for governments, banks and large corporations around the world. They would also conduct forensic investigations after data breaches and cyber attacks to establish what had gone wrong and how to fix it. They were in great demand.

They had very different upbringings. Adam was the child of an alcoholic father who died falling down stairs when Adam was fourteen and a distant, remote mother more interested in the social whirl and 'being seen'. Adam's saviour was his grandmother. She was fierce and caring and determined to protect Adam from his own parents. She and Adam had become best friends in the process.

It wasn't sad for Adam when she died because they had had long discussions about the inevitability of it. She was ready to go and she knew that Adam was ready to take over. Adam was seventeen, his best friend had died, his mother immediately disappeared abroad with her latest affair but somehow he felt strong, capable and excited for the future.

Finn had a happy, but unconventional, childhood. He was brought up, close to the River Thames, mainly by his Dad, a senior police officer specialising in cyber-crime and fraud. His Mum lives in north London. The unconventional part was that his Dad lived with Finn's step-dad and his Mum lived with his step-mum. It worked out well for Finn because nobody was upset or critical of his sexuality. It was

a family joke that Finn's sister, who lived with their Mum, was the dark family secret, because she was straight.

Adam and Finn lived in Covent Garden in a large apartment overlooking The Piazza. Adam had arranged for the whole apartment to be redecorated and the wooden floors refinished after his half sister had been shot dead there by armed police while brandishing a handgun and threatening to kill Adam.

Although he had been determined not to let it affect him, and wouldn't be driven from his home, Adam had some nights, lying awake wondering if he'd ever shake the memory of that night. He would always remind himself that he was stronger than that, and more crucially, he wasn't alone now.

After agreeing to their weekend away, Adam and Finn were both in the kitchen watching the Moka pot, listening to the burbling sound of the coffee being forced up through the grounds. Adam's phone buzzed and he looked at the screen.

"Hmm..." he said out loud. "It seems I'm being summoned by my godfather"

"I didn't know you had a godfather," Finn replied, pouring the coffee.

"Well... he would be my godfather except that neither of us believes in God. He's actually one of my grandmothers very best friends and he's been my friend since before I could talk"

"You've never mentioned him before"

Adam laughed "Well... he's a little out there and quite a handful. Would you like to meet him?"

They were fortunate that they both had flexible working lives and Finn would often work long into the night because he was able to survive very happily on four to five hours sleep a night. Adam replied to the message and they set off to walk to his godfather's home in St James. Covent Garden is well placed in London and just about everywhere they wanted to go was walkable, including Finn's Dad's house.

On the way, despite being quizzed intensely by Finn, he would only reveal that his godfather was called Robby.

“You’ll see, soon enough” he teased Finn.

It was a twenty minute brisk walk and they opted to avoid Piccadilly and walk along Jermyn Street, which runs parallel.

“That’s where the King has his shirts made” said Adam pointing to a posh looking shop.

“Do they sell t-shirts?” Finn laughed.

A few moments later they crossed St James’s Street with its gentlemen’s clubs and bespoke shoe makers. They passed into a narrow side street and there was a hush. A sort of quiet acknowledgement of the discretion and understated wealth that surrounded you. This was not the place where the offspring of oligarchs and oil sheiks showed off their supercars and flashy watches. This was a place where wealth was generational – often for hundreds of years.

Adam stopped outside an unassuming looking 1960’s building. He pointed a few feet to the end of the street where an older building was just visible from where they were. An imposing gate stopped anyone passing.

“That was the London home of the Spencer family. It’s still owned by Princess Diana’s brother but it’s leased to some Rothschild or other. This is where some properly rich people live!”

“So... Robby is rich then?” Finn asked

Adam grinned with a real twinkle in his eye “You’ll see...”

He pressed a bell next to the front door and it clicked open almost at once.

In the lift Adam was still grinning furiously.

“Don’t say I didn’t warn you”

“What about? You haven’t told me anything” Finn was excited, confused and apprehensive in equal measures.

As the lift door opened...

“ADAM! My dear boy. You have abandoned me for so long!” Robby shouted as he crossed to the entrance.

Robby was wearing a hand knitted rainbow beanie hat, silk shirt and a cashmere pashmina draped around his shoulders. He hugged Adam tightly before releasing him and holding him at arm’s length.

“You look gorgeous. Something suits you well.” Robby’s eyes slid across to Finn like a silent movie star in her big close-up.

“You must be Finn,” he said quietly. He looked Finn up and down slowly “Adam, if I was two hundred years younger you would have a fight on your hands. Come in, come in, both of you”

He took Finn by the arm and led him in through the front door as Adam followed.

“So, Finn...I’ve heard lots about you but I demand to know everything.”

I’ll certainly try Mr...” Finn hesitated

“It’s just Robby darling. Actually Robby Dorset but everyone calls me Robby”

“Robby!” Adam stretched out the word in a low, serious voice as if telling off a puppy. “Tell the truth”

Robby made a dismissive gesture so Adam spoke again.

“Finn Williams, may I introduce His Grace Robert Louis Deauville-French, the 11th Duke of Dorset, scion of the aristocracy, scandalous gossip and one of the very best people ever to exist on planet earth”

“Oh piffle, nobody cares about that stuff nowadays. I’m just plain old Robby Dorset” Robby smiled, even though he knew it wasn’t true.

“Anyway, come through and sit. A lovely young man from Fortnum and Mason has just delivered some cakes.”

Chapter Two

The cakes were wonderful. Robby poured tea and they had an hour of laughter and stories. Most of Robby's stories were of scandalous behaviour. Born into the aristocracy in 1941 Robby had, like all his peers, been shipped off to boarding school at seven years old. It was a deeply troubling time but Robby was a fighter, metaphorically and literally. His school was founded in the 16th century and there had been a Deauville-French there almost continually since its founding.

It was this, and the prestige of having a Duke enrolled, that saved Robby's neck several times. But, eventually his father, the 10th Duke, and the school decided that enough was enough. Robby left school at fifteen leaving the other boys with no source of pornographic magazines, no in-house bookmaker, no cigarettes and considerably less mayhem.

Robby, even after leaving school, was the eye of a hurricane of intrigue, fun, gossip and excitement. He was a friend to royalty, titans of industry, dustmen and bricklayers. He was truly a man who could place himself at any level in society and be accepted. It didn't matter that he was, to quote himself, 'as camp as a row of tents' somehow everyone warmed to Robby.

"Now... let's get down to business Adam. I am eighty five years old - although I could pass for fifty" he whispered to Finn - "and I want you to buy this apartment."

Adam cocked his head to one side. "Why on earth would you sell up here? You love this place"

"That's true, but I want you to have it. You see, I bought this place when I was a young man in my twenties, as it was being built. I bought it" he emphasised "before I became Duke and with my own money. So, my property, along with some other stuff I own, is not

part of the Dukedom's property. When I die, some dreadful old cousin will inherit the Dukedom and all the estate."

Robby was getting quite agitated "What I don't want is for my cousin, or any of his dreadful family, to have any claim on anything I really care about. They're awful people, they probably buy furniture in IKEA...whatever that is"

Robby laughed at his own joke and his pretend pomposity.

"If I leave it to you in my will they will probably contest it and you'll be neck deep in lawyers for years." Robby held up a hand to silence any discussion "No, I'll sell it to you and that will be legally binding. Then I can use that money to move to a retirement home in my dotage"

Robby told them the proposed price.

"Don't be ridiculous Robby, it must be worth ten times that." Adam exclaimed.

"Probably twenty times to be honest. It was a sweet deal when I bought it. Let me give you a guided tour Finn"

He led Finn by the arm around the massive apartment. It had 5 bedrooms, each with its own bathroom, an industrial sized kitchen and a large sitting room complete with a log fireplace.

There was a large library with one wall covered with floor to ceiling bookcases.

"They're hand made in walnut from trees that grew on the Dorset estate" Robby looked wistful and Adam rested his hand on his arm. He put his hand over Adam's and gently patted him. You could see him, almost physically, shake off any sadness.

"Honestly I had the estate's carpenter build them and install them. The poor man was called Ted and I thought he was about a hundred years old but he was probably nearer sixty. He struggled on his own with me flapping around behind him, no use at all."

Robby laughed at the memory.

"We had to smuggle all the timber to the workshop and then to London without the Estate Manager knowing. It was before I became the Duke and he might have tried to charge me! What a liberty"

Robby smiled again. He wasn't a man to have regrets and all his memories were happy ones. He'd never settled into a long-term relationship but he had had what he described as 'several great loves'.

"Anyway... wonderful old Ted and I agreed that he would take the secret of the bookcases to the grave and he did. Bless him"

He led Adam by the arm back into the sitting room. Finn followed but he had an uneasy feeling. Nothing bad, just something tweaking low down in his super-analytical brain. He dismissed the thought.

"This is why it was a sweet deal," Robby told them. "The building is owned by the Crown Estate but I was granted a 990 year lease. Any repairs to the exterior or the common parts and I only have to pay 1% of the total costs. Last year they replaced the roof, all the lifts and renovated the stairwells and it hardly cost me anything."

"I cannot tell you the unspeakable things I had to do to get that deal" Robby said dramatically "sometimes three or four times" he whispered conspiratorially to Finn.

Robby might have been 85 but he was quick witted, funny and outrageous.

"I'll make some more tea" Robby announced "and we can go and get some sun on the terrace"

Finn pulled a face as Robby left the room. "I don't get it, Adam. If Robby is a Duke, doesn't he own half of London anyway? Why is he worried about a lease from the King?"

Adam laughed, watching a pair of pigeons on the window ledge. "It's a bit of a weird British quirk, Finn. Robby owns the lease, but the 'freehold' - the actual land the building sits on - belongs to the Crown Estate."

"So the King is his landlord?" Finn asked, leaning forward to watch the pigeons, who were either fighting or courting or possibly both.

"Does Charles come around to collect the rent personally?"

"Not exactly," Adam said, pointing toward a grand building near the park. "George III made a deal back in 1760. He was broke, so he handed over the income from all his lands to the government. In exchange, the taxpayers give the Royals a 'Sovereign Grant' - basically an allowance to keep the palaces running."

"And anyway, knowing Robby the annual rent is probably pennies"

Finn pulled his phone out, doing a quick search online. "Wait, the Crown Estate brings in nearly a billion pounds a year now, doesn't it?"

"Exactly. It's a massive property empire. Everything from retail blocks in Regent Street to the literal seabed around the UK. The government gets the billions, the King gets his grant, and guys like Robby get a nine-hundred-year lease and a very posh address."

Finn shook his head, impressed. "A nine-hundred-year lease. Talk about long-term planning."

Robby returned carrying more tea on a tray and led them out onto the terrace. There were views across Green Park to Buckingham Palace.

"We can wave at the King" said Finn

"Not over there. It's a horrible, draughty old place with too many rooms. More like an office." Robby pointed to the left where you could see the top of a large building a short distance away "wave in that direction because that's where he lives when he's in town"

"It's all a bit posh for a simple lad" said Finn

"From what I hear you're very far from simple Finn. I hear you do some sterling work" Robby mentioned the name of a small private bank Finn had dealt with.

"How do you know..."

“Oh don’t worry, it’s still confidential. I’m very good friends with the Chairman” Robby brushed the air as if it was an irritant. “I’m also friends with Ken McCallum, who I think you know”

Ken McCallum was the Director General of MI5 and Finn had indeed met him.

“Have I been vetted?” Finn asked smiling

“Absolutely” cried Robby “I couldn’t let my favourite person in the world get tied up with someone unsuitable. Even Maltese Tony likes you and he doesn’t like anyone”

It was impossible not to laugh along with Robby. He was infectious, full of fun and charismatic.

And, of course he knew Maltese Tony, the owner of the oddest, and best, secret cafe in London.

“So, we’re decided,” Robby continued. “You’ll want to renovate and rebuild and... oh wait... have you seen the garden?”

Finn looked around the massive terrace “There’s a garden too?”

“Come with me,” Robby shouted. Behind a trellis a spiral staircase went up to a large roof garden. It put Adam’s garden to shame, covering the whole of the roof structure. There was a building in the corner, which Robby told them was a separate two bedroom apartment for staff

“From the days when one could afford servants” Robby said wistfully.

“OK Robby, you’re on,” said Adam impulsively, “but you can’t move to a retirement home because you’ll die of boredom in three months. I’ve got an empty apartment under mine in Covent Garden so why not move there rent-free until you go ga-ga and then we’ll put you out to grass.”

“Wonderful! I can sit in the Piazza in the sunshine, drink coffee and flirt outrageously with waiters.”

Chapter Three

They had just arrived back at their apartment and Finn announced he wanted Robby to become his godfather too.

"Why have I never met him before?" he demanded.

Adam laughed "He went to Tuscany for the winter to stay with an old friend - I think she's a Countess or a Princess or something.

Anyway, it's this amazing old villa and they turn the heating up to oven-roasting temperature, then they sit and gossip all winter and eat in the most amazing restaurants."

"Wow, what a life," Finn shook his head. "He should write his autobiography."

"A publisher did suggest that to him but Robby claimed libel lawyers would have a field day."

Just as Finn sat at the kitchen counter his mobile rang. He looked at the display and saw it was his father.

"Hi Dad," he said brightly.

"Never mind that, tell me about Robert Fallon"

Finn smiled. He could tell when his Dad was in full-on detective mode. It wasn't personal, it was just focused. Since moving out Finn had taken to leaving a daily message for his Dad and step-Dad just to keep in contact and update them. He'd mentioned the upcoming weekend away.

"Nothing much to tell you I'm afraid. All I know is his name and that he's pretty influential in a low-key background kind of way. James and Anna were invited but they wanted us to go as moral support and a bit of fun"

"And obviously Fallon sees James as a route to his mother?"

“I guess so” Finn replied “I think Margaret was invited first but threw James in as a sacrificial lamb”

“Hmm... maybe” Marc said “she’s probably got a fair bit on her plate at the moment”

Finn could almost hear a click as Marc switched from detective to Dad mode.

“Steven is running a 10k the weekend after your trip away. Why not come over to dinner that night?”

“Maybe we could sign up for it too?” Adam asked over Finn’s shoulder “Are there any places open?”

“Not sure Adam, I’ll check and get Steven to drop you the info.”

“You’ll need to sign up too Dad, it’ll be a family effort” Finn laughed. In reality his Dad needed no impetus to exercise and they would often compete together.

Finn’s step-dad was Steven Hawkes. He’d been in a relationship with Marc since Finn was a toddler and had been a huge part of both their lives – figuratively and literally.

Steven was a huge man – 6 feet 5 inches and built like a nuclear shelter. Even twenty years after leaving the Royal Marines he was extremely fit. While Finn, Adam and Marc would aim to complete a 10k run in around 50-55 minutes, they knew Steven would be on the finishing line waiting to welcome them.

As he said goodbye and disconnected the call Detective Chief Inspector Marc Williams looked around his office. Not really looking, more like sensing the air.

“Robert Fallon...” he mused out loud. “Too many hits Mr Fallon. Too many fluid links. You don’t get mentioned that much without there being something odd going on”

Marc had been promoted to DCI last year. On the surface it was because of a huge money laundering ring that Marc and his team

had busted wide. He couldn't prove it but he suspected some considerable political clout had come to bear as well.

When Adam was the target of an attempted murder last year James Brand, now their friend, was the unwitting victim of mistaken identity. Finn had received lots of first aid training when he worked for MI5 and had helped enormously in stopping the bleeding and reassuring James. Doctors in the hospital had said James didn't go into shock simply because of Finn's calm and efficient way.

By coincidence, Steven was the first paramedic on the scene because he rode a specially adapted motorbike to cope with the London traffic. It helped that Steven was battle-hardened and had dealt with a lot of stabbings and gunshot wounds.

Margaret Brand, James' mother, was the Foreign Secretary at the time. One of the most powerful politicians in the UK and, surprisingly well-liked by her colleagues and the public. She had personally thanked all concerned, especially noting the family connection.

About a month later Marc was summoned by his boss's boss and given a promotion, a bigger investigatory team and a better set of offices.

He didn't complain. Whether it was the big money laundering result or political pressure, he was happy. Always good to have a friend in high places as Margaret Brand had told him herself. He kept it to himself but he thought it was unlikely that even the Police Commissioner had Margaret Brand's personal mobile number on speed dial.

Marc looked up across the open plan office. Although he had a private office Marc liked to work from a desk in the main space. It was a good team with a great work ethic and similar mindset. This was a team more likely to celebrate a win by going to the gym instead of the pub.

It was a standard joke amongst his team that if Marc was in the office he was either telling someone off, getting told off or looking at something unsavoury on the Internet.

Although the first two were true Marc didn't need to look at the internet. He was happily married to a man who put most underwear models to shame.

"Brandon...?" he called to a younger man two desks away. "What do we know about Robert Fallon"

Brandon Drake was a Detective Constable in his late twenties. He had been recruited into the team by Marc as early as possible because Marc had been tracking his progress from his first day as a police officer. Brandon had excelled in his Computer Science degree and had studied Accountancy on his own time. Via a friend he had recently taken a series of mock Accounting exams and passed each with distinction. All he needed to become a qualified Accountant was three years work experience but that wasn't part of his plan.

Brandon loved working in cyber-crime, loved the forensic breakdown of information, establishing links and solving riddles. He had hated being a copper on the beat but it was a means to an end. He was tall and thin and not really a man to break up a street fight but he was calm, measured and logical.

He had once disarmed a knife-man in the street just by smiling at him and listening for a few minutes. His colleagues called him a hero but, many months later, he confessed to Marc that he nearly wet himself.

Because Brandon had also recently passed his Sergeants exams Marc was manoeuvring for the budget and the timing to make that happen for him.

"Robert Fallon? Nothing much really. Lots of threads that don't seem to go anywhere. He seems to be well-connected but not very well liked. There is one oddity though"

Marc got up and walked over to Brandon's screen as he pulled up some information.

“We think he’s got a tame politician or three. We’ve got CCTV of him leaving certain bank premises with what looks like a brown envelope. Then he has lunch with someone and suddenly... no brown envelope”

“Could that be ‘Misconduct in Public Office’?” Marc laughed “seems to be very popular at the moment”

“That could be a minefield boss... and I suspect we’d get shut down pretty quickly by the big-boys upstairs” Brandon replied.

“You’re probably right. Don’t waste a lot of time on it but can you put together a short report on what we know, what we suspect and what suspect we don’t know?”

Brandon smiled. It was exactly the sort of digging and delving he enjoyed.

As Marc walked away he turned and said

“You’re looking a bit buff Brandon. Have you been working out?”

Brandon blushed in confirmation but didn’t back down

“That sounds like sexual harassment in the workplace boss. I could get compensation and counselling”.

They both laughed. Brandon wasn’t intimidated, in fact he’s been to his boss’s house several times for summer-BBQ’s and meals with the team. It was part of the reason he loved his job.

Later that night Marc was lying at one end of the sofa with his partner Steven at the other end. He was massaging Steven’s feet because Steven had just finished a hectic shift as a paramedic and hadn’t sat down all day except on his motorbike between jobs.

It was their accepted norm that Steven rarely talked about his job because he liked a clear separation between his happy home life and what could be a traumatic, stressful workday. The people he dealt with were often experiencing the most frightening, difficult moment of their lives and Steven was a calm presence in the middle

of it. That didn't mean he was unaffected by it but he did like to maintain a professional objectivity around his work.

They often discussed Marc's work, as long as nothing too confidential came out. Tonight, because of the link to Finn and Adam, Marc had told Steven all about Robert Fallon.

"Cryptocurrency" said Steven.

"What?"

"Any time you tell me about some odd little scam or scheme that doesn't feel right, there's always an element of cryptocurrency involved. I'll bet you a pound to a penny that, if Fallon is bribing members of parliament they will all be on some committee investigating regulation of cryptocurrency and they will be against any government control"

"That's a pretty interesting idea..." Marc conceded "Now tell me everything you know about cryptocurrency"

"I know enough not to put my pension into it" Steven laughed. "But go on... give me the full lecture Professor Crypto."

Steven leaned back, watching Marc's hands as he massaged the tension out of his feet.

"OK," he teased, "if Fallon is bribing MPs with digital gold, how does he actually hand it over? Is he passing around encrypted briefcases?"

Marc snorted, not looking up. "Hardly. It's cleaner than that. And a lot older than you'd think. People have been trying to build a currency outside the reach of the taxman and the big banks since the eighties, but it didn't really 'pop' until the 2008 crash."

"Right, the Nakamoto paper," Steven said, tapping his temple. "I remember reading some stuff."

"Satoshi Nakamoto," Marc corrected, his voice dropping into that rhythmic tone he used when he was lecturing. "The mysterious creator, just a presence online really. He published the blueprint for

Bitcoin and then just... vanished in 2010. Left behind a 'Genesis Wallet' that hasn't been touched in sixteen years."

"How much is in it?"

"Last time I checked? A shade over a hundred and thirty billion dollars." Marc stopped the massage to look Steven in the eye.

"Imagine that, Steven. One of the richest people on the planet, and nobody even knows if they're still breathing."

Steven gave a low whistle. "And Fallon? How does he move it?"

"Probably a 'Cold Wallet,'" Marc explained, miming a small rectangle with his hands. "It looks like a standard USB drive. You keep it offline, away from hackers like our son and, to the rest of the world, that money doesn't exist. But the second you plug that key into a laptop and connect to the server, you're not just carrying a thumb drive—you're carrying the keys to a kingdom."

Steven looked toward the window, the London lights reflecting in the glass. "A kingdom worth killing for."

Chapter Four

Just as Finn disconnected the call from his Dad, Adam's phone started to ring on the kitchen counter.

"What have we done to be so popular?" Adam asked out loud.

He looked at the display and saw it was Lizzie.

Lizzie had been his grandmother's housekeeper for many years, even before Adam was born. She was a staunch ally of Elspeth and joined in the protection of Adam against the worst excesses of his alcoholic father. Adam would sometimes hide away in Lizzie's small flat, downstairs in his grandmother's giant Knightsbridge house. His parents would drift in and out of Adam's life, despite all living in Elspeth's house, but Lizzie and Elspeth were constants – dependable and solid. They made sure Adam had a happy and safe childhood.

When he was older his grandmother told Adam that Lizzie had come to work for her just after she had lost her fiancé. He had been killed in a car crash not long after their engagement. She had been bereft and Elspeth, who knew the family from her early days in Devon, had offered her a job. Her fiancé had been the love of her life and she never wanted another relationship.

When Elspeth died Lizzie asked Adam if she could stay in her tiny flat in the basement because she was nervous of moving away. Adam rented the main part of the house and Lizzie stayed in the flat for two years until she confessed to Adam that she'd like to move out of London. Adam found, and paid for, a retirement village where Lizzie settled happily with lots of new friends and planned activities.

Lizzie was the first person Adam introduced Finn to because, as Finn rightly pointed out, she was more like a mother than Adam's own mother. They made a regular trip out to the countryside to visit.

Now, however, Lizzie sounded distraught.

"Adam, I don't know what to do. I am so worried"

Adam told her he was putting the phone on speaker so Finn could hear and asked what was wrong. In a slightly disjointed way, the story unfolded that Emily Morgan, Lizzie's niece, had been in an abusive relationship with a man who had been put in prison for assaulting her. Adam had met Emily and liked her a lot but he didn't know anything about this relationship.

"Well, she was quite ashamed to be honest." Lizzie explained "she's normally so confident, so capable but somehow this man..." Lizzie faltered.

"Tell me why you think she's in danger" Adam asked

Slowly the story emerged that Emily had been in a relationship with a man called Lewis Kelly. It had started happily but gradually Kelly became more and more controlling. A slow process that cut Emily off from her friends and family until one day he exploded and beat her up over a broken plate. Despite hospital treatment, Emily returned to their home and he was full of apologies and promises. Two weeks later something else had put him over the edge and this time the police got involved. Because of the severity of Emily's injuries Kelly was prosecuted and sentenced to five years in jail.

An appeal against the sentence resulted in a reduction to four years and, after less than two years inside, Lewis Kelly was out on licence.

In the UK, being released on licence means there are conditions attached to the release and, if breached, the offender goes straight back to prison. In this case Lewis Kelly was supposed to have no contact with Emily.

Lizzie told them that she'd just had a bad feeling and Emily wasn't answering her phone. Then, after she had called twenty times, an angry sounding man had answered Emily's phone.

"If you call her again I will fucking kill her" he shouted before hanging up.

Lizzie was frantic. She rang Emily's next door neighbour who said he hadn't seen her. He had Emily's door key so he went in to check

she wasn't home. Lizzie called the police but was fobbed off because Emily was an adult and 'not vulnerable'.

So she called Adam.

"Lizzie, give me Emily's phone number," Finn said.

She read out the number and then said "She even gave me her emergency number in case her phone was stolen but I tried dialling that and it makes no sense."

"How long is this other number Lizzie?" Finn asked.

They could hear her counting softly to herself before saying it had fifteen numbers.

Adam watched Finn's eyes darting from side to side as his brain sifted the possibilities.

"It's an IMEI number" he said, half to himself.

The IMEI number on a phone is the International Mobile Equipment Identity and each phone has a unique number.

"Read out the number carefully Lizzie, then give us fifteen minutes to sort something out"

As Adam hung up Finn spoke quickly.

"I can track the phone but, if I do it, it's against the law. Fortunately I have a very good friend and business partner in Russia who can do this in five minutes."

"Let's do it," said Adam.

Finn checked his watch. "He's three hours ahead, we'll ruin his dinner"

Finn sent a message with the details and a few minutes later his phone buzzed. No questions had been asked.

"You have to love this guy" Finn smiled "He's sent a location for satnav and a satellite image of the house. He says he thinks the phone is in the back of the house, probably downstairs"

“How can he know that?” Adam asked.

“Well, if you’re the local police you can probably get a rough location but, if you can access the intelligence services, you can locate it down to a metre. You’d be shocked what ‘big brother’ can find out”.

Adam checked a car-share app on his phone. “There’s a car about five minutes from here if we run it” he told Finn.

“We can be there in half an hour if the traffic is OK, but don’t let me forget to buy twenty packets of dark chocolate Hobnobs and DHL them to St Petersburg.” Finn replied.

Adam looked confused but Finn just laughed.

“Don’t blame me, it’s a small price to pay. I can’t help it if the poor man came to London and became addicted to chocolate biscuits.”

As they drove south through London they discussed their plan. They couldn’t call the police yet because Emily might be perfectly well and happy with Lewis Kelly. If they established she was in any danger, or that Kelly had broken any of his release conditions they would involve the police.

Finn suddenly wondered what his Dad and step-dad would say but he put the thought out of his mind. Time for a lecture later.

London is no different to many cities. Once prosperous but separate neighbourhoods fell into disrepair and, in some cases, disrepute. People were priced out of the inner city and started to move further out, but commuting further in. Eventually the lower prices attracted more professional people, more prosperous people and ethnic food shops made way for artisanal coffee shops and it wasn’t unusual to see high end kitchens being delivered.

Sadly this area was only at the beginning of that transition. The main shopping street had a lot of empty units, there were a number of charity shops and a fair sprinkling of optimistic estate agents offices. Their window displays prominently featured words and phrases like ‘opportunity’ and ‘refurbishment project’ whilst ignoring the reality of failing local schools and street crime.

Unknown to Adam and Finn Lewis Kelly was using his mother's old house. His mother had died while Kelly was in prison and he had inherited the house. Not in any formal way because he was too stubborn to get help with his mother's estate. Some would argue too stupid but Kelly had a fiercely independent streak – everything had to be done his way and if he couldn't do it without help, even professional help, he wouldn't do it.

Growing up it had just been him and his mother. His father had disappeared before he was born and his mother struggled with finances, childcare and her own mental health. She had inherited the house from an elderly maiden aunt who, feeling sorry for her lone struggle, had left her the house so she would always have a roof over her head. It wasn't much, and Mrs Kelly had done nothing to maintain the house, but it gave some stability.

Lewis Kelly was noted as a trouble maker at school and he had left at the earliest legal time. He'd drifted into warehouse work and from there into petty crime. He had genuinely thought he was clever stealing from the warehouse but he didn't last long.

When he met Emily he claimed he was a salesman at a local BMW dealership but in reality he cleaned cars and made tea. His view of the world, and his place in it, was heavily skewed.

At another time, prison could have been the making of him. Training courses in useful skills and rehabilitation work when he was released might have made a difference. The current prison system suffers from under-funding, under-staffing and chronic overcrowding. Kelly was lucky to escape without a serious addiction problem because drugs were rife.

Adam parked the car just short of the address they'd been given. It was a two up, two down, end of terrace house in poor condition. The estate agents would say it had 'potential' and was solidly built but 'ripe for renovation'.

"We could bang on the door and claim to be Jehovah's Witnesses," Finn suggested.

“We could but it would be nice to be invited in and I don’t think they ever are”

As they spoke a man emerged. He was in his late twenties, about six feet tall – the same as Adam and Finn. He looked fit but in a stringy, skinny way. He didn’t look like he’d ever eaten anything healthy in his entire life.

“Lewis Kelly do you think?” Adam asked.

Finn nodded and pointed out the empty plastic carrier bag Kelly was carrying. “Just off shopping by the look of it”

“A pair of idiots would go through that side gate and look in through the downstairs windows in case we could see Emily” Adam said quietly.

“What are we waiting for then?”

As Kelly turned a corner about 50 metres away, they locked up the car and crossed the road. The side gate was unlocked but some dead plants meant it needed a good shove to open it. They left it ajar and went to the back of the house.

The first window was the kitchen but there was nothing to see there. As they walked a few more steps they could see into the dining room and there was Emily.

All three of them had shocked expressions. Their eyebrows shot up and their eyes popped. Emily was bound to a chair with cable ties and had a gag in her mouth. Her face was bruised and tear stained. Although she was fully dressed her clothes were torn and dishevelled. Emily had obviously put up a fight.

“We should call the police,” Finn said.

“Yes...” Adam replied but he reached forward and moved the large sliding glass doors. To his surprise they were unlocked and slid easily if roughly.

Bizarrely Adam thought to himself that the doors needed lubrication but shook his head slightly to clear his thoughts.

“Don’t worry Em, you’re safe now.” he said, taking the gag from her mouth.

“Scissors, top drawer” Emily said, nodding towards a chest of drawers in the corner. Emily wasn’t cowered. She wasn’t afraid. She was angry and determined. “He won’t be long”

Finn started cutting through the cable ties, taking care to avoid hurting Emily. Just as the last tie was released they heard the front door open.

“Who the fuck are you two?” Lewis Kelly had returned because he’d forgotten his wallet but had seen the side gate open. He was ready for trouble. Ready, and carrying in a large kitchen knife.

Adam started backing away with his arms wide, herding Finn and Emily towards the open garden door. Finn was half carrying Emily because she’d been tied up, immobile, for so long.

“Emily, come back in here if you know what’s good for you” Kelly said in a low menacing voice.

“I don’t think so mate” Adam replied “we’re going to make her safe then call the police”

“Emily, I will fucking kill you.” Kelly shouted.

Finn had already got Emily outside when Kelly lunged forward towards Adam. Finn watched as Adam stepped to his left to avoid the attack. He grabbed Kelly’s right wrist pulling him further forward and sideways whilst slamming his left arm into Kelly’s neck pushing his upper body back. As Kelly’s knees buckled Adam wrapped his arm around his neck and squeezed.

The attacker was suddenly under attack.

Adam squeezed the headlock tight while still holding the knife away. Kelly was folded in half and struggling to breathe.

“You have two options” Adam told him calmly “You can either drop the knife now or I can wait until you lose consciousness and you’ll drop the knife anyway. Your choice.”

With his knife hand pinned and his head in a headlock had no option but to follow Adam's instructions. He dropped the knife. Finn stepped forward and kicked it away out of reach.

“Good man” said Adam, as if in encouragement “Now, we’re both going to turn so you’re on your belly and you can straighten your legs. I want you to point your toes away flat and if you move your toes... I’ll break your neck. All clear?

Lewis Kelly nodded his head as best as he could and they changed their position with Adam still holding the headlock. He nodded at the cable ties to Finn who immediately bound Kelly’s hands and feet.

“Maybe now we should call the police,” Adam grinned at Finn.

“What the Hell was all that? Finn exclaimed.

“Didn't I mention it? I'm a Second Dan black belt in Aikido” Adam laughed.

“A second dan... you could have been killed.”

Adam saw the fear in Finn’s eyes “But I wasn’t and it’s all over now” he said gently. “I’ll call the police while you get Lizzie on your phone for Emily.

The police came, took statements from everyone and took Kelly away. An ambulance came and checked Emily over but she got a clean bill of health.

“Come back with us Em” Adam told her “You can have a long, hot bath and an early night” He looked at his watch, it was late. “Well, an earlyish night.”

Emily was grateful for the offer. She didn’t want to go home alone, even knowing Kelly was locked up.

“Even better,” said Finn. “We’re going to a spa hotel in a few days. It’s a Murder Mystery Weekend but don’t let that put you off. Come

with us.”

Back at the apartment Emily opted for a long hot shower. Finn had started preparing a meal for them all and, when Adam went to call Emily, he found her fast asleep on the bed wearing a towelling robe and a pair of his old gym shorts.

He pulled the cover over her gently and dimmed the light. As he pulled the door almost shut he heard Emily sleepily say “Thank you Adam, thank you both.”

Chapter Five

Brandon Drake stood in front of his boss's desk with a frustrated look on his face. He'd hoped to turn something up for the Detective Chief Inspector.

"Let me guess," said Marc Williams. "Nothing concrete on Robert Fallon but a lot of dead-ends and rumour."

"Pretty much. I can't access bank records with a warrant, and we have no grounds, but I'd give odds that he's drawing cash to pay off some politicians with influence."

"Probably the same with insider trading I reckon," Marc said.

"Yeah, he does appear to live beyond his means. Not a lot of income but seems to live the life of Riley. Nothing overtly criminal that I can find without some sort of justification."

"OK, stick him on the back burner. He might think he's fireproof with all his posh mates so we'll just keep an eye on him."

Brandon wondered how many people Marc kept on his back burner. He knew there were a lot of people that skated close to the thin ice, and many more who managed to stay within the law by skilful bending and stretching the limits. They utilised loopholes and anomalies and relied on their money and influence to stop any real investigation."

It was one of the things that Brandon liked about this team. The whole team was committed to the law. It wasn't jaundiced and world-weary. There was no jaded acceptance of 'the way things were'.

Back at his computer Brandon dragged the file called Fallon into a folder just called Stuff. It was right there, on his desktop, right in front of his face.

You can call it the back burner, he thought but let's keep it near the forefront.

Adam had booked what turned out to be the last available room for Emily. She was lucky there was a cancellation just a few minutes before Adam called.

They'd checked various transport options, including trains, but in the end Adam opted for his normal car service. What they had offered Adam was a Mercedes van with blacked out windows. From the outside it looked like a commercial vehicle that a builder or plumber might use but inside the interior had six deep comfortable seats, four of them around a small table. The seats were all reclinable and were finished in cream leather. It was luxurious, understated and discreet. Adam thought it was perfect.

James and Anna arrived in a black cab just a few minutes before the 'van' driver

As they pulled into the hotel entrance a young man arrived to collect their cases and another car pulled up behind them. They all politely said thank you and goodbye to the driver because it was the courteous thing to do. Adam quietly slipped some banknotes into the driver's hand as he left.

As they entered the hotel Finn could hear the couple getting out of the other car. He wasn't sure if they were bickering at each other, the porter or the driver but it sounded quite tense. They were still muttering angrily as they followed on into the building.

"Hello, my name is Adam Griffin," Adam said smiling at the young man behind the reception desk. "I have reserved two rooms."

"Griffin - like the famous detective?" the young man asked.

"Yes, I changed my name because people couldn't spell Poirot," said Adam with a straight face.

The Receptionist looked a little flustered until Adam smiled. He read the man's name tag.

“Don’t worry... Alfie, I’m just messing with you. Adam Griffin, like the detective.”

“Adam can never escape his grandmother,” James said quietly to Anna.

“Oh, they’re guests. I thought the decorators had arrived in their van” said the bickering woman close behind them. No attempt to lower her voice.

Finn watched as Alfie, the young man behind the desk, looked Adam up and down. It was cautious and tactful but, nevertheless, Finn knew he was checking Adam out. And why not, thought Finn. By any objective scale Adam is gorgeous but back off Alfie, he’s all mine and I don’t share.

All checked in, they agreed to unpack and meet in the spa in thirty minutes because Adam had booked treatments for everyone. The plan was to rotate between the sauna, massage room, facials and manicures. An afternoon of pampering.

Later, they had arranged to meet in the bar before dinner. Adam and Finn had collected Emily on the way down, her room was just two doors away from theirs, and James and Anna were already sitting at a table with drinks. Because neither Adam or Finn drank much they opted for an alcohol free white wine recommended by the waiter. Surprisingly it was good, much better than they had tasted before.

The group chatted happily until they were interrupted by the arrival in the bar of the bickering couple. They seemed to have calmed down. They almost seemed nice. They stopped by the group and the man spoke.

“Hello, I’m Simon Metcalf and this is my wife Lorraine” he said smiling.

There were nods and acknowledgements around their table but Finn noted that nobody had offered more than their first names.

“Are you here for the Murder Mystery Weekend or just the night?” Mrs Metcalf asked. She also smiled but it wasn’t a smile that

reached her eyes or even caused her lips to part.

Maybe they're still fighting, thought Finn.

"Yes, we're here all weekend. Until the death... so to speak," Adam smiled warmly but any sense of cordiality died before it reached Mrs Metcalf. She seemed frosty to say the least.

"Well, good luck with solving the clues," Mr Metcalf jumped in and gestured his wife towards a nearby table.

"AHHH... MY WONDERFUL GUESTS ARE HERE ALREADY" a voice boomed out across the room.

Robert Fallon was a huge man. Not tall, but vastly overweight. He was in his mid fifties but cultivated the appearance of someone much older. His posture and demeanour seemed to have been taken straight out of P. G. Wodehouse but without the humour.

He walked with a stick and, almost inevitably, it was a silver topped cane. His dark, three-piece suit was obviously expensive and hand made but he managed to look dishevelled and untidy. He had a full head of silver grey hair that looked expensively barbered but his barber was fighting a losing battle. Perhaps the most striking thing was that he was wearing a bow tie and a monocle. Strung across his large belly was a gold watch chain that disappeared into a waistcoat pocket.

Finn and Adam exchanged a glance and they both looked at James who avoided their gaze.

"Mr Fallon, how nice to see you again" said James rising from his seat and extended a handshake. Fallon took his hand sideways, like a Dowager Duchess and for a split second Finn thought James was expected to kiss his hand.

"Call me Robert, James. I can't have my favourite new friend relying on formality" he then grasped both hands over James' hand and held it tightly for several seconds too long.

"Let me introduce everyone," James said, squirming his hand loose.

He introduced everyone and Finn was left feeling as if he needed to wash his hands – or preferably shower. For someone with such a solitary job, Finn felt he was a good judge of people. Nothing about Fallon felt comfortable or endearing. The bonhomie, the blustering jollity, even the kind words and compliments felt off-kilter. Finn watched him greeting everyone and could see the calculations going on behind his eyes.

This was a man with no empathy. A man with no emotional attachments.

Robert Fallon, Finn decided, was a psychopath.

Fallon's parents were solidly lower middle class. His father was mercilessly hen-pecked by his overbearing wife. Constantly aware of 'how things looked' Fallon's mother pushed her son to academic success. She basked in his achievements and trumpeted his accomplishments to neighbours, acquaintances and family. In fact, she would have stopped people in the street to tell them how capable and clever her son was.

By eleven years old Fallon was a high achiever and was rewarded by a place in a prestigious school. It wasn't a private, fee paying, school but nevertheless it was well regarded. Fallon listened to his mother berate his father because his lowly financial position meant they couldn't afford a boarding school. That was the very least her young protégé deserved. Robert, she informed her husband, would far outshine him in income, style and acclaim.

It was later in his school career that Robert Fallon made an interesting discovery. An older teacher showed a suspicious interest in him. Many boys would have given the man a wide berth but Fallon was fascinated. Fascinated by the way the man became infatuated. Fascinated by the way he could manipulate the man. Fascinated by the control he could exert.

They did have sex, although Fallon was under-age at that time. He was underwhelmed by the physical act, but the control... the power... was exhilarating.

It was the beginning of a journey that led Fallon to understand that he was more interested in controlling people than any sense of intimacy or love.

He continued his relationship with the teacher for several years, all through the remainder of his school years and into university. When the teacher unexpectedly died, Fallon felt nothing. He had already dictated the teacher's last will and testament so he was confident of inheriting a large house and some savings but as far as losing someone he had been close to for five years - he felt nothing.

Just as Fallon was finishing university both his parents died. His father beat his mother to death with a bottle of ketchup and then hanged himself in the stairwell of their home.

Robert Fallon's first concern was whether their gruesome deaths at home would reduce the value of their house. He was, of course, their only beneficiary.

Fallon introduced his own small party.

"This is Giles, my long suffering assistant and this is my wife Louise." he gestured vaguely in their direction as if they were an unimportant part of his world.

Giles was a man in his early twenties, a little shorter than Finn, with a slight figure and an unmistakably foppish posture. He had a washed out look to him, as if he was worn out. Drained by something, or maybe by someone.

Louise Fallon, who seemed to be the last consideration of her husband, was using crutches. She smiled at the gathering in a nervous way, as if she too had been depleted. Giles helped her into a chair and she smiled at him weakly. Finn noticed a moment between them. He couldn't put his finger on it but it seemed like quiet acquiescence, a sort of mutual recognition of their separate but still shared fate.

Robert Fallon ignored them both and launched into his, well rehearsed, act as a raconteur and bon-viveur.

Adam had sensed Finn's disquiet. He found it surprisingly reassuring that they were so attuned. He had also concluded that the performance they were seeing was just a mask. A sprat to catch a mackerel. Robert Fallon didn't care about him or Finn. James was the prize but only as a stepping stone to Margaret Brand. Adam regretted agreeing to the weekend except maybe it gave them a chance to protect their friend.

After a short while in the comfortable bar, the head waiter came through and told them their table was ready. The restaurant was small and intimate and their group had a table for eight in a discreet corner.

There were name cards in beautiful handwriting. Adam could tell there was some sort of hierarchy, a power play maybe. Certainly some subtle messages.

Robert Fallon took the head of the rectangular table with his wife, Louise, at the far end. As far away as possible. On Fallon's right side was James with Anna next to him. Emily was at the far end next to Louise Fallon as if an unexpected afterthought. In fact, after the last few days of turmoil Emily would have been happier eating from a tray in her room.

Adam sat opposite James, on Fallon's left. He concluded that he was deemed worthy because he had a famous relative, and was possibly wealthy. Adam hadn't quite worked out all the angles yet but he was certain Fallon had. Giles sat next to Adam with Finn relegated to sit next to Mrs Fallon.

Finn smiled at the place markers because he instantly realised he'd been marked down as un-noteworthy. That suited him fine because he was already tiring of the barrage of bluster from Fallon.

The meal was excellent and Finn struck up conversations with Emily and Louise Fallon. To his surprise Louise was dry-witted and quite

acerbic. She spoke quietly but was clearly well-educated and had a good grasp of current affairs, music and theatre.

She was fascinated that Finn and Adam lived in Covent Garden but demurred when Finn invited her to visit. Perhaps it was because Finn made it shockingly clear it was an invite to her and not her husband.

During the course of conversation it transpired that Louise Fallon was in dire need of an operation to replace both her hips. Although she was nearly crippled, and in great pain, her husband refused to pay for private treatment. The National Health Service waiting list is long. Finn read between the lines that he had deliberately cancelled or muddled her appointments, which he thought was probably just to make her suffer. Finn decided that Robert Fallon was a hideous man who, contrary to his own outward appearance, kept his wife penniless and reliant on him. Although Fallon liked to project an image as a well-to-do gentleman Finn was rapidly growing to hate Robert Fallon.

His wife appeared kind and gracious. If I was her, I would have killed him years ago, thought Finn.

At the far end of the table Adam and James were subjected to a non-stop, barely interrupted monologue from Fallon about who he knew and what he had done. Names were being dropped like autumn fruit in a windy orchard. Adam also noted that Fallon, although untidy and creased, was fastidiously and expensively dressed, unlike his wife and assistant.

“Young people nowadays just need more discipline. My mother was very strict with me and it did me no harm.” Robert Fallon was now holding forth about what is wrong with the world. It’s not a conversation, more of a lecture.

“Yes, Elizabeth was a very difficult person.” Louise Fallon told Finn.

There was a tense moment when James had mentioned Los Angeles in passing. Fallon said he’d never been to California but Giles piped up and said “I thought you lived in Pasadena for a while”.

There was a moment when Fallon looked really irritated but his face immediately went impassive before he replied.

“No Giles, I have never lived abroad, but you’re right, now I recall. I went to a Layman’s conference for the High Anglican church in Pasadena. It must have been more than fifteen years ago. I barely remember”

The conversation moved on but a couple of glares told Adam that Giles was in trouble.

Giles turned away and made conversation with Finn. To Finn’s surprise he liked Giles. Although he had an air of emotional fragility about him, Giles could be funny and self-deprecating. When Finn mentioned the gym Giles claimed he had never partaken of any sport or exercise in his life.

“And clearly... I’m not the only one” he said quietly with a real twinkle in his eye. He didn’t need to look round at Fallon who by now was tucking into a large dessert.

After dessert was cleared and he had politely declined coffee. Adam announced that he needed his beauty sleep and it had been a tiring day.

“Oh my dear boy, I cannot imagine anyone less in need of beauty sleep” Fallon replied. He stretched out to cover Adam’s hand with his own but Adam moved in time and used both hands to push back his chair.

“Thank you so much for an entertaining and informative evening” he said to Fallon who murmured agreement.

James and Anna jumped up like scalded cats and claimed they must make their way to bed too because they wanted to be fresh for the oncoming murder. They both smiled but neither of them managed to make the smile look sincere.

Fallon pulled out a gold pocket watch from his waistcoat pocket and looked at it ostentatiously.

Sell that and pay for your wife's operation, thought Finn. He noticed that the antique looking watch had a USB flash drive attached to it and the juxtaposition of old and new struck him as odd. Finn smiled inside thinking it was unlikely Fallon could operate a computer, or indeed anything technical.

“Well, it’s time for my evening indulgence anyway” said Fallon pulling a large cigar from his pocket. “I believe there is a wooden shelter in the gardens for us smoking pariahs.” He laughed at his own joke.

As they passed through Reception Finn stopped at the desk.

“What time are you here until Alfie?” he asked the young man behind the desk.

“Eleven, more or less. The night receptionist is always late so... 11ish.”

“When that gentleman” he nodded gently towards the retreating figure of Fallon “has gone to bed and left the bar, would you send me a message on this number please?” He handed Alfie a piece of paper with his mobile number written on it. “I need to come down and do some work but...”

“Don’t worry, I know what you mean” grinned Alfie.

Walking up the wide, impressive stairs to the first floor Finn smiled at Adam.

“I noticed you didn’t say it was an enjoyable evening.”

“Oh God, that man is such a bore. Honestly, if he’s looking for influence or favours I think you’d give in rather than have to spend another minute with him.”

“One weird thing though...” Finn said. “His wife says funds are so short he won’t pay for her operation but he can still pay for all this and smoke a big cigar”

“Even more intriguing, the cigar was a ‘Cohiba Robusto’ so they probably cost about eighty quid each. You can tell by the band around it.”

“Wow, how come you know so much about cigars?”

“Robby used to smoke them years ago. He had a thirty year old Cuban boyfriend... don’t ask,” Adam laughed.

Chapter Six

Simon Metcalf had eaten a miserable meal. His wife Lorraine had been quiet, distracted and lost in her own thoughts. He had booked this weekend because, although they were newly-weds, it wasn't their first time around the block. Lorraine had been married before to an American as far as Simon could ascertain but she was very cagey about him.

Simon had been married several times before, often bigamously. He had made a career out of marriage, mostly to older, wealthier women. He targeted carefully, extracted as much as he could and then just disappeared. One of the consequences had been a prison sentence but Simon considered that to be an occupational hazard. He had been sent down for fraud, theft and bigamy.

On his release he was surprised at how little information was on the Internet about him so, with the help of a prison acquaintance, he changed his name and started again. He didn't know that he had a legal marriage to Lorraine because his last victim had been so distraught that she had fallen for his lies and deceit she had committed suicide.

Despite his stint in prison Simon had led a life of luxury funded totally by a string of well-meaning but gullible victims.

Now Lorraine had gone up to bed Simon had announced he was going for a cigarette in the garden. As he followed the path down towards the lake he passed the hugely obese shape of Robert Fallon returning from the same task.

They exchanged a terse greeting, both lost in their own thoughts.

The smoking area was actually a wooden gardeners tool shed with a pergola to one side providing cover from the weather for any smokers. Simon was pleased to see it was empty. He'd been told

that the hotel was quite empty tonight but, as soon as the event was under-way they were to be jam-packed.

He was halfway through his cigarette when a voice spoke softly from the shadows around the tool shed door.

“Well, well, well Philip Clarke, as I live and breathe. I wonder what little scam you’re up to.”

Simon jumped, partly at the sudden interruption but mainly for the use of his real name.

A figure came forward a step into the dim light.

“What the...” he exclaimed “Lewis Kelly? What the hell are you doing here?”

“Well I’m just chasing my stupid bitch ex-partner but maybe this could be more fun... more money involved too.”

Simon pushed Kelly back through the door of the tool shed.

“You can’t be here. And you certainly can’t be involved” he said angrily. He pushed his way past Kelly, deeper into the darkened shed. There was some moonlight coming in through the window and he could see Kelly smiling at him. He didn’t need this sort of spanner in the works.

“So what is it?” Kelly sneered “Another wealthy widow thinking she’s found true love? Another grubby little scam?”

“You’re too stupid to be involved in a scam like this. You’re more of a deranged stalker and a wife beater”

Simon couldn’t afford to antagonise Lewis Kelly but he was angry. They had been cell-mates when they were both in prison, Simon for fraud and Kelly for beating up Emily. It was a relatively short overlap but clearly Kelly remembered him well.

“Maybe I am stupid but I’m clever enough to fuck it up for you... if you don’t cut me in”

Kelly was smiling, he clearly thought he'd stumbled onto a nice little scam and he could profit from it.

"Not a chance mate." Simon sounded firm but he felt shaky. He put his hand out to a shelf to steady himself.

"OK..." Kelly's attitude changed, he sounded threatening. "I'll be back in the morning to talk to that lovely "wife" of yours." He turned to walk away.

Simon panicked. He couldn't afford to let that happen. His hand was resting on the handle of a hammer. Without thinking he picked it up and swung it wildly. It was a wide arc with all the anger Simon didn't even realise he was holding in. The hammer head connected with a dull thump. Loud enough to make Simon look out of the window for fear of discovery.

"That's what you get for messing with me and if I see you again you'll get worse." he hissed at Kelly.

He looked down at the prone figure. Kelly wasn't moving. Simon looked closely, not touching, but he could see a bloody mark on the corner of a big tool box. Kelly had hit his head on the metal corner on his way down. If Simon didn't kill him, the box finished him off.

What had he touched? The hammer obviously. What else? Should he move the body? DNA? He needed a reason to be there. A cigarette? He sheltered there earlier for a cigarette during the rain. Brilliant he thought, random DNA explained.

As he stepped over the body and left through the door, he looked down at his hand, still holding the hammer. It was like it was someone else's hand.

"Can't keep that" he thought "Need to get rid of it."

He lit a cigarette and felt calmer. He hatched a plan for the hammer so now he needed an alibi... a timestamp.

Chapter Seven

Alfie had just sent an 'all-clear' message to Finn when he sensed someone heading to the desk.

"Good evening Mr Metcalf " he said looking up.

"Hello... Alfie" Simon said, reading Alfie's name badge. When Adam and Finn had done it earlier it felt friendly and courteous. Now, it just felt patronising.

"I wonder if you could do me a favour." Simon continued. "My wife bought me this Smart watch for my birthday but it's more stupid than I am" He smiled at Alfie, who wasn't buying it.

"Could you look up one of those atomic clocks on the Net for me so I can try and set it to the precise time?"

Alfie did, and then watched silently as the guest fiddled with the watch

"That's got it" Simon said "Damn technology!" he laughed and Alfie just smiled thinly.

Simon spent a few moments trying to engage Alfie in small talk about technology but eventually gave up and headed upstairs.

On the way upstairs he passed Finn coming down.

"Thanks Alfie, you're a lifesaver." Finn smiled at Alfie.

"Can I get you anything?" Alfie asks him.

"No I'm just going to set up my laptop somewhere out of the way and get on with some work"

Finn needed very little sleep especially when compared to Adam who definitely needed a full eight hours. At home, Adam would go to bed and Finn would stay up working until joining Adam four or five hours later. At the hotel they had decided that Finn would go

downstairs even though their suite was large. Finn didn't like to disturb Adam.

Earlier, after escaping from the dinner table, Adam and Finn had sat on the terrace of their room waiting for the all-clear from Alfie. There were two comfortable hardwood armchairs and they had found thick cushions in a cupboard. They sat, holding hands looking out over the lake and up at the stars.

"That's the Big Dipper," said Finn.

Adam looked at him. "Are you telling the truth?" he said smiling

"Maybe... but maybe not," Finn laughed.

"Actually the only astronomy fact I know is that we can see a star called Betelgeuse in the Orion constellation." Finn waved a vague hand at the sky and they both knew that neither of them could identify that group of stars. "We can see it because it's 700 times bigger than our sun and about 600 light years away. Put that in perspective, if we could travel at the speed of light it would still take 600 years to get there."

"And..." Finn was warming to his lecture "Voyager 1 was launched 50 years ago and is travelling at 40,000mph, twenty four hours a day, but it's less than 1 light day away.

They both heard a plop and a splash from the lake.

"And that..." said Adam "Is a fish jumping up to laugh at your Astronomy lesson!"

Adam stretched upwards "I think I'm going to bed" he told Finn.

"I'll get my stuff and I'll see you in a couple of hours. Keep my side warm!"

He'd been working for about half an hour when he saw Giles come down the stairs. Finn had positioned himself carefully, close to a power socket but tucked away behind some large palms. A casual passer-by would probably not notice him.

He watched Giles speak to Alfie and then head his way. Clearly Giles was intent on a similar hiding place.

"Hello Giles," Finn said brightly.

"Oh... Finn... I didn't realise. I'm sorry I'll go somewhere else."

"No, don't worry, sit down"

"I can see you're working. I won't disturb you."

"No, it's fine" In truth Finn was a little bored by his work tonight and welcomed the respite.

Alfie turned up with a very large looking gin and tonic on a tray.

"Sure I can't get you anything?" he asked Finn.

Finn shook his head and held up a hand. He wasn't really a drinker. Not a moral thing, he just didn't like the taste much.

As Giles sat down he let out a long sigh.

"It must be hard being an assistant and on call all the time," Finn said.

"It's hard working for some people" Giles replied and Finn noted he slurred slightly. It was obvious the drink before dinner and the wine with their meal had taken its effect. Finn thought more alcohol probably wasn't the answer.

They exchanged small talk for a few minutes and Giles quickly worked through his drink. Finn noticed that Alfie was handing over to a new receptionist and he gave Finn a little wave as he left.

Giles hadn't really noticed the changeover but he gestured towards the new receptionist for another drink. When it arrived Finn thought the new receptionist didn't really fit in with the up-market image of the hotel. Whereas all the staff, including Alfie, looked well groomed and very smart, this man looked like he had slept in his clothes.

As he left Giles suddenly spoke "He really is a hideous man you know?"

"Mr Fallon? Yes, I thought that too, to be honest"

“He treats his wife terribly, he tries to pretend to her that he’s got no money but he’s loaded. He treats people like complete shit unless he thinks he can get something out of it.” Giles was beginning to get upset. Together with his obvious drunkenness it was quite uncomfortable.

“Take tonight. You and Emily were shunted down the table because he couldn’t see a benefit in you. He couldn’t afford to upset you because you’re friends with his prize but...”

“James?” Finn interrupted him.

Giles said Fallon only invited James to get close to his mother. Giles didn’t know anyone else but said Fallon had invited several other people for the following night.

“So he’ll be holding court again tomorrow?”

Giles nodded. “He’s such a shit. He’s not even faithful to his wife you know”

“With you?” Finn asked.

Giles’ face drained of colour “Oh my God, you can’t... he’d literally kill me... how did you know?”

“I don’t know. Intuition? Gaydar? A shot in the dark?”

It was like the floodgates opened and Giles told Finn how he had been thrown out of boarding school because he’d openly professed love for a fellow student. Physical relationships were common, and ignored, but ‘love’? That was a step too far. The object of Giles’ passion was the sporty son of a well known business leader.

Despite their relationship being common knowledge amongst the student body, and a lot of the staff, he denied everything leaving Giles adrift.

When Giles’ parents were called they were furious that their son had caused them such embarrassment and removed him from the school immediately. Back at home, after a blazing row, Giles’ father threw him out with barely a small suitcase of clothes.

Not for the first time Finn thought it was fortunate that he had grown up with such well-adjusted parents.

"I only had a few hundred in the bank but I was fortunate that I could stay with my cousin in the Barbican. She was a lifesaver initially." Giles told him. "After a few weeks though she got fed up and found me a bed with one of her friends. Actually it was more like a mattress in a cupboard but..." Giles faltered and Finn knew what was coming next.

"Then I met him. I don't even remember how, or who introduced us. I'd been working a few terrible jobs in coffee shops, even a burger place, so when he offered me a job as his 'assistant' I didn't even ask for details. I moved into a tiny room in their house and he was really nice to me. He bought me clothes, took me to places. I didn't realise but he was showing me off. It turned out he had a group of friends with similar arrangements"

"What did Louise think about all that?" Finn asked.

"Well, at first, I thought she just didn't care but then I realised she'd seen it all before. We became... not really friends, more like fellow hostages. Both trapped in a way. Actually I like her a lot."

Giles had almost finished his drink and Finn hoped he wasn't going to signal for more.

"Why not just get a new job?" he asked.

Giles just laughed. "Well, you might not realise it, but I am a bit thick Finn. All that money spent on my education and not a scrap of paper to prove it. No qualifications at all and, if I'm totally honest, no skill, talent or aptitude" He drained his glass and said "I would feel guilty about all the wasted money if I didn't hate my parents so much."

"No, I'm stuck with him even though he is so horrible to me. As he always says, no-one else would take me" Giles stood up, a little unsteadily.

“I’ll leave you to get on with your work but... please Finn, don’t tell anyone what we have discussed. I exaggerated when I said he’d kill me but not by much. Rich and powerful people think they are a law unto themselves.”

As he watched Giles weave unsteadily towards the stairs Finn mused he thought of himself as rich and Adam was definitely very rich. He couldn’t imagine either of them becoming so entitled and uncaring. It made him shudder as he packed up his stuff.

Chapter Eight

It was late the following morning when Frank Sloper arrived for work at the hotel. He'd had a pre-arranged dental appointment so he didn't start work until nearly 11am. That was fine because the hotel General Manager knew Frank was reliable, and a hard worker. He left Frank to run his own domain - the extensive grounds around the hotel.

Almost every task was mechanised so Frank was able to manage the estate on his own. He brought in contract labour a few times a year when needed but normally he preferred to work alone. He didn't need to work because he had a good pension but he liked to fill up his time.

Frank wasn't a gardener by profession. He was a soldier. After 30 years in the Army he had retired as a Warrant Officer Class 1 - the highest rank for non-commissioned officers. Frank Sloper had an air of quiet confidence and a switch in his demeanour that turned him into a calm but very scary man. He also had a way of calling young, green officers stupid without actually offending them or breaking any rules.

As he approached his tool shed, Frank frowned. The door was never locked but it was always shut tight. Now, it was ajar, just an inch. Momentarily he felt his hackles rise, a sense of danger, something out of the ordinary. He didn't know why, he didn't care why. It was enough to put him on alert.

Standing slightly to one side Frank pushed open the door of the shed. Peering in he saw a body lying prone on the floor. He saw the blood and the wound on the back of the head but Frank had seen a lot of bodies, in several war zones. He didn't need to confirm this one was dead. The purplish-blue shade to the skin and its waxy appearance were all he needed.

Frank closed the door quietly and made his way into the hotel.
General Manager first then the Police he thought. Let someone else
deal with all the hassle.

Chapter Nine

Adam and Finn had gone for a run instead of breakfast. There was an unstated agreement to skip the hotel dining room at breakfast in the hope of avoiding Robert Fallon. After running ten kilometres they both jumped in the shower and sneaked back downstairs like a pair of super-spies.

They knew that the spa had a small snack area and it was their intention to eat there before relaxing in the pool and gym. As they entered they saw James and Anna sitting at a table. James paused, holding a Danish pastry mid-bite.

“Don’t kill me” he said with his mouth full. “Do you hate me? Was it awful? It was awful wasn’t it?”

Anna looked sideways at him “Why are you apologising to them? You didn’t apologise to me”

“You love me, so if I’m in the poop, you have to come with me” James blushed because he realised it was the first time he’d used the L word in front of Adam and Finn.

“Never mind all your lovey-dovey slop.” Adam said, trying, but failing, to sound angry. “We know you’re just in here hiding from ‘He Who Cannot Be Named’.”

“We did think it was a safe place because it’s not likely he’s ever been to a gym is it?” Anna said.

They spent ten minutes laughing together and eating pastries before Emily appeared. Her hair was wet and she’d just come from the gym.

Emily and Anna were a similar age, approaching thirty. Anna had studied for many years to gain a Doctorate in Economics but Emily had left school, escaped school she said, as early as possible. She’d spent eight years travelling the world and, if pushed, had lots of stories of local buses in Peruvian mountains, regional Warlords in

West Africa and cigarette smugglers in Australia. She was smart and resourceful, even if things did just happen to find her. That made Adam more surprised that she had fallen for Lewis Kelly.

Without make-up Adam could still see some traces of the bruising on Emily's face. She obviously healed quickly physically but he wondered if she had an emotional toll. On the face of it, she didn't. Emily had been angry. Angry at herself but more angry at Lewis Kelly.

"I know exactly why you four are here" she said and all five of them laughed because no more explanation was needed.

Emily pulled up a chair and sat. They discussed the events of the previous night. Finn told them how Giles had come back down, very drunk. He left out the most confidential parts but told them that Giles was deeply unhappy but felt trapped.

"Well I had a result at breakfast" Emily told them all "I was on my own and a guy came and asked if he could share my table"

"Ooooh, is this the start of a holiday romance?" Anna asked.

"No I don't think so, but he is quite dishy" She described the man and they all recognised him from the dining room last night except James.

"Anyway... a small amount of gossip. Apparently he's a trader in Crypto currency. He had a go at selling some to me but, first off I didn't have a clue what he was talking about and secondly, I have no money. He's here to meet some bigwig to discuss a big transaction."

"I thought all that stuff was illegal – all to do with money laundering" said James.

"No, it's far from illegal but it does attract some dodgy money" Finn told him.

"He also told me another little snippet" Emily continued "you know that grumpy old battleaxe who arrived at the same time as us?"

"Mrs Metcalf ?" Adam interrupted.

“That’s her. Turns out he recognised her from America. Her then-husband, not the current guy, was a leading player in the development of something called Bitcoin but when he talked to her she denied all knowledge. He’s totally convinced though”

Before anyone could reply the hotel General Manager appeared at their table.

“I’m sorry to interrupt” he said “there has been an incident in the hotel grounds and the Police have requested that nobody leaves the building. They will interview everyone later.”

“What sort of incident?” asked Finn.

“I really shouldn’t say but... a body was found in the gardener’s tool shed and the police suspect foul play”

Finn frowned, then smiled. “Has the murder mystery started? I thought we were starting this evening”

“Oh no sir, I’m afraid the murder mystery event is cancelled. The police have demanded that nobody is allowed to check in or out of the hotel until they say so. We’re all asked to gather in the reception area.”

As they made their way out of the spa Finn laughed quietly. “It’s a bit ironic to have a murder at at Murder Mystery weekend. Straight out of a ‘you know who’ book”

“First thing I thought too” replied Adam “I forgot to tell you, I rang Robby before I went to sleep last night. You should hear what he has to say about Robert Fallon”

Nobody could accuse Robby of liking Robert Fallon. Because of his title and upbringing Robby was a member of more than one ‘gentleman’s club’ in London. He had met Fallon when he had become a member of one club that was frequented by the upper echelons of the clergy. Robby saw through Fallon immediately. He found Fallon’s superficial bonhomie and his obviously fake attempts at friendship to be irritating. Robby found it astonishing that so many people seemed to be taken in by him. He realised early on that it

was sheer weight of numbers. If that many influential people knew Fallon, and apparently confided in him, then they must be seeing something you had missed.

Robby would have none of it. He knew a bad egg when he smelt it, and Fallon reeked.

Not long later Robby had blackballed Fallon when he attempted to join two influential clubs, one of them the oldest of its type in the world. He had spoken directly to the chairman of White's.

"Mark my words, there is something rotten about him and he will, sooner or later, bring this club into disrepute"

Robby's opinion carried great weight. Both clubs counted the King and the heir to the throne amongst their members and Fallon was discreetly and quietly rejected.

Fallon was enraged. He believed that he had the natural grace and style that made him ideal but he knew better than to kick up a stink. Although he was the product of a minor state school and ran his own exclusive wine importers he didn't quite have the right connections yet. He would, he thought.

In truth anyone looking closely at Robert Fallon would have noted some worrying discrepancies. His wine business seemed to operate barely at a level to pay Giles salary, let alone afford him the lifestyle he enjoyed. Once, when pressed, he had claimed to be the recipient of a trust fund, but that wouldn't stand up to any scrutiny.

"To quote Robby directly," Adam told Finn. "Fallon is an oily little shit with some shady goings on and a massive scandal bubbling under the surface."

"How does Robby know all that?" Finn asked.

"To be honest I think it's a mixture of intuition and gossip but Robby is a lot more astute than he lets on. He likes you to think he's a bit fey and muddle-headed but he's really as sharp as a tack and doesn't miss much."

All the guests had been asked to gather in the reception area and Finn and Adam made their way there. Alfie was back on reception duty and he beckoned them over.

“I’ve been told to cancel all the guests for tonight that were coming for the events and hand over details of people who checked out this morning. There will only be about a dozen people staying tonight and the police say they are not to leave” he said conspiratorially.

“You should make notes Alfie, like a real Murder Mystery. My money is on Colonel Mustard in the study with the dagger” Adam told him.

Alfie looked confused. “Cluedo?” said Adam. More confused expressions so Adam just waved and said “It’s a board game, don’t worry.”

“and a really terrible joke,” whispered Finn with a smile.

Once everyone was gathered a man appeared and announced that he was Detective Inspector Alan Coates and he, along with his colleague Detective Sergeant Bill Cross, would be interviewing everyone individually.

“But, for the avoidance of doubt, we are investigating an unexplained death in the hotel grounds because there are reasons to suspect foul play. The unfortunate man has been identified as Lewis Kelly”

There was an audible gasp from Emily and Finn looked at Adam, shocked. Before Adam could reply Inspector Coates spoke again.

“Perhaps I should start with you Miss?”

Adam watched as Emily stood and walked off with the policeman. Sergeant Cross made his way over to Adam and asked him to come into the nearby meeting room.

Chapter Ten

Adam's interview was straightforward and short.

"So you were in the bar all evening." Sergeant Cross asked him after establishing some background facts.

"Pretty much. We were just chatting with Emily and our other friends."

"You didn't leave? Didn't go to the toilet? Didn't need to get rid of any beer?" Cross asked.

"Neither of us really drinks so... only two small glasses of non-alcoholic wine all night. Not good for bar profits I'm afraid. Then we had dinner with Mr Fallon and his party."

Cross had some further questions and Adam realised he was starting to establish a timeline. In investigations, it is important to verify a sequence of events and then see where different witness statements fit into the timing.

There were fifty people booked in for the Murder mystery evening but most were only staying one night after the meal and the entertainment. Only eleven were booked for the whole weekend.

As the police began their interviews Finn slipped into his now familiar corner and rang his Dad. He outlined what had happened and asked Marc if he was able to find out why Kelly was at the hotel when he should have been back in prison.

Ten minutes later Finn's Dad called back.

"Don't broadcast what I'm about to tell you but essentially it's a massive cock-up. Instead of being shipped back to jail under the terms of his release Kelly was given Police bail and told he'd be summoned before a Magistrate in due course."

"So... just let out?"

“Pretty much. There’s some big-time arse covering going on but the long and short of it is, they treated him like it was a first offence and nobody checked his record properly”

“I wonder how he tracked her here?” Finn asked. “She left her phone at home deliberately and we gave her Adam’s old one with a new SIM”

“Best guess? She’s carrying some sort of tracker.”

Finn mulled over those words for a moment before saying “Credit card?”

“Almost certainly,” his Dad replied.

“If Emily doesn’t have a rock solid alibi Dad, she’s going to be the prime suspect isn’t she?”

“She’s certainly where I would start”

“Dad, I think we need the best criminal lawyer money can buy and we need him in Oxfordshire ten minutes ago.”

“I know just the woman,” Marc replied.

After exchanging some more thoughts Finn disconnected.

Emily emerged from the interview a few minutes later.

“They said they will want to talk to me again,” she told Finn, slumping down into the seat next to him.

“Show me your wallet Emily,” Finn said.

Emily frowned but pulled a small wallet from her jeans pocket. She passed it to Finn who quickly sorted through a small number of credit and debit cards and pulled out a credit card sized black card.

“Do you know what that is?” he asked Emily.

“Yes, Lewis gave it to me ages ago. It’s a card to block someone reading your credit cards from a laptop. It stops fraud.”

Finn pulled a face. “It’s a tracker Emily. That’s how he knew where you were.”

“Oh for... how can I be so stupid?” Emily gasped.

“Don’t be so hard on yourself. Most people wouldn’t know, and at least we know how he got here. I’ll tell the police when it’s my turn.” Finn took the card, holding it by the edges. Maybe Kelly’s fingerprints were on it, he decided.

Adam arrived back from his interview and Finn pointed at the tracker that he’d laid on a magazine on the table. He explained what they had discovered.

“Well that’s a big question answered. Did you go straight to bed last night?” he asked Emily.

“Yes, I went out like a light and didn’t wake up till 8am, then I went straight to the gym.”

“So... nobody can back up your alibi?”

“Are you asking if I had a bit of a fling last night?” Emily gave a weak smile “Sadly not, although I could do with it. For two reasons now”

“CCTV in the corridors?” Finn said “If it shows Emily going in and not coming back out, that’s corroboration. If she climbed down the drainpipe for 30 feet, she’d have grazed her hands, or dislodged dirt. Then she’d have to climb back up”

“So the CCTV should be enough?” Adam looked at Finn and they both spoke at the same time “Alfie!”.

“I’ll go” said Adam “just in case they call you in”

Finn briefly told Emily about his conversation with his Dad. He told her Kelly had been released because of a massive error but to keep that quiet for now. He also told her that she would be a prime suspect unless they could establish a solid alibi for her at the time of death.

After a few minutes Adam returned. He looked happy.

“The CCTV is really clear and all good. It shows Emily going into her room and leaving at 8.10am. Interestingly it shows Robert Fallon leaving his room, just after you went downstairs, and visiting Giles

for about half an hour before going back to his room. Then Giles is seen leaving for the bar, looking slightly wobbly. An hour later he comes back, even more wobbly and you return about 3am, which fits with what I just told the police.”

“I hope they don’t recycle their data to save hard disk space,” Emily said.

Adam just grinned like a dog who had eaten the cat’s dinner.

“Alfie gave you a copy didn’t he?” Finn smiled at him.

Adam produced a small flash drive. “I said we’d buy him dinner next time he’s in London.”

“As long as he’s not expecting breakfast,” Finn laughed.

They sat and watched as people were called in to their interview. There seemed to be no logic to the order but eventually Finn was called in. He picked up the magazine with the tracker balanced on top of it.

“Let them find the CCTV themselves” Adam told him. Finn nodded and replied “We’ll keep that under wraps for now. They’ll find it, unless they’re totally useless.”

Finn sat down in front of Detective Sergeant Cross, who just looked at the magazine. He didn’t look friendly, in fact he looked just like his name implied.

“What’s that?” he demanded.

It’s a rechargeable tracker card and, I suspect that when you access Kelly’s phone, you’ll find this device is linked. I have just taken it from Emily’s wallet, in the front right hand pocket of her jeans. I think there is CCTV in the lounge area so you can see the chain of events.”

Finn had deliberately mentioned the CCTV because, although he thought these police officers were probably smart, he was also aware that other officers had released Kelly by mistake.

“And what do you think this means?” Cross asked Finn gruffly.

“I think it merely explains how Kelly knew where Emily was. When he was let go by your colleagues, instead of being put back in prison, he was obviously led here to continue his obsession.”

“So, Emily Morgan was Kelly’s victim and somebody kindly removed the threat”

“I’m sure you will connect the dots DS Cross but the picture won’t be Emily,” Finn said smoothly.

Cross ignored him and proceeded with questions about Finn’s movements the night before. He was particularly interested in the reason why Finn was downstairs in the hotel lounge. Finn told him that Adam had gone to bed and, because he needed very little sleep, he had come downstairs to work. Finn confirmed his encounters with Simon Metcalf, Alfie, Giles and the night receptionist who Finn couldn’t name.

He also confirmed that Alfie had messaged him to say Robert Fallon had been and gone, because Finn had specifically wanted to avoid him. Cross must have already interviewed Fallon because it hadn’t surprised him.

As they ended the interview Finn stood up to leave. He paused.

“There was a plop and a splash,” he said out loud, as if to himself.

DS Cross looked up sharply.

“About half past ten there was a plop and a splash, as if someone had thrown something in the lake,” he said.

“You’re sure of the time?” Cross asked him.

“Almost certainly because it was about a minute after the all clear message from Alfie. Adam must have forgotten but he claimed it was a fish jumping out to laugh at me. We were sitting on our terrace”

Adam and Finn swapped places when Cross called Adam back in to confirm the new information.

A few minutes later they were sitting close together on a sofa, looking out over the hotel lounge.

“Do you think someone here killed him or someone outside?” Finn asked quietly.

“Well, the butler probably didn’t do it but I can’t see who would have a motive here... except Emily.” Adam replied.

“You don’t think that, do you?”

“No, even if we didn’t know her, there’s no evidence. Maybe they’ll find out more if they find the murder weapon in the lake.” Adam spoke slowly as if turning over possibilities in his head.

“Maybe...” he continued “someone here isn’t who they claim to be. Maybe a clever computer person could look into that,” he grinned, looking forwards, not at Finn.

“You’re a sly and devious young man Adam Griffin. I’ll get on it right away.”

“You never know” said Adam “if you come up with anything interesting, you might get a special reward” Adam waggled his eyebrows, which made Finn laugh.

Finn pulled out his laptop and started a list of all the people that were staying in the hotel. He added in a couple of the staff that he knew but realised that a deeper dive was something only the police could do.

Where to start? He thought. He crossed himself and Adam off the list and then Emily. He was happy with her alibi but maybe he’d come back to her if nothing else jumped out. James and Anna were in the same category. He knew them, but he’d still check. They were a lower priority for now though.

There were eight people on his list. Obviously there had been some people that had checked out that morning but he had a starting point. Once he had worked through his list he’d get to the currently unknown guests. Finn had no doubt the hotel’s IT system was easily

accessible to someone with his skills but he'd go for the easy option first. He dialled the hotel number on his mobile.

Alfie answered professionally and politely giving his full name as an introduction. That's one question off the list thought Finn as he noted down Alfie's last name.

"Alfie, it's Finn Williams. Don't look up but I'm just in the lounge."

Despite what he'd been told Alfie did look up and he locked eyes with Finn.

"I just need two names from you," Finn continued.

"I can't give... Why do you need two names?" Alfie replied.

"Because our friend will be the prime suspect in the murder. It was her ex-boyfriend that was killed and he'd been to prison for stalking her and beating her half to death. We need to find out some info and I'll be quicker than the police."

Across the room, Alfie frowned. "What do you need?" he said.

"The name of the tall, dark haired guy who seems to be on his own. He's sitting over by the window. And the old guy who took over from you last night."

"Anthony Shannon is the guy by the window. Nice enough but a bit of a stick up his arse." Alfie said softly. "The night receptionist is called Geoff Carson. He's bound to have an alibi because he's always in the pub down the road until two minutes before he starts work. That's why the old sod is always late."

"Thanks Alfie, we'll upgrade your dinner from a happy meal to a proper restaurant." Finn told him as he hung up. He smiled at Alfie across the room.

Finn had been aware of Adam sitting next to him. He could almost hear the cogs turning in Adam's brain. Fitting together pieces, dismantling them. Comparing back-stories that they knew and looking for links they hadn't found yet.

“The Bitcoin guy is a complete unknown so, maybe start with him but the Metcalfs are... troubling me. It's like they don't fit together. Even Fallon and his wife have some sort of connection. Not exactly chemistry but you can see some sort of dynamic between them. With the Metcalfs, everything feels wrong from their body language to the way they speak to each other.”

Finn agreed with the plan so starting looking for information. Because of his specialist skills Finn had quick access to information others couldn't find. Obviously the police would find all this information but Finn wasn't burdened with the need for warrants, permissions or court orders.

After about ten minutes he sent Adam a message using an encrypted messenger app. Adam was sitting next to him but Finn didn't want to speak out loud.

‘Anthony Shannon, sometimes known as Tony Shipton, is a genuine dealer in crypto currency. He's sort of legitimate although he has been invited to help the police with investigations in Spain and Panama. He's reasonably well off but hardly rich. He has some interesting, and very dicey, contacts on his phone. I'm currently accessing his email on his phone and he is here to meet up with Robert Fallon to discuss a seven figure sale of crypto currency with payment going to a bank in Lichtenstein. All very hush-hush.’

Adam looked across at Shannon. He was sitting alone, looking out of a window across the lawns towards the lake. It amazed Adam that Finn was currently snooping around inside his mobile phone while Shannon was holding it in his hand.

‘How do you manage to do that stuff?’ Adam messaged back.

He felt Finn laugh quietly before his phone buzzed again.

‘I used all my hacker skills but it was a great help that his only password is... password. Some people are just stupid’

Adam laughed as he read the message.

For the next ten or fifteen minutes Adam surveyed the scene in front of them. People were being brought in to be interviewed by the two detectives. Some staff that he'd never seen before and even a couple that Adam thought had checked out this morning. He overheard them tell another police officer that they lived locally so decided to come straight back instead of needing to go to the police station. Probably just looking for a bit of local gossip Adam decided. It looked like the police were beginning to wrap up their interviews when Adam's phone buzzed again.

'This is interesting, and you were right. Mr & Mrs Metcalf got married about a month ago. She's fairly straightforward. Born in Surrey and still lives in the county. Born as Lorraine Mundy but got married to Gerald Lucas in California 2005. She was an actress but only managed one TV episode and a bad B movie. Most of her time she was a waitress.

Her husband, Lucas, was an early developer of crypto currency. He was an early mover and shaker in Bitcoin but he died in a car crash in 2011. She came back to England with enough cash to buy a big house and live reasonably well.

She met Simon Metcalf online six months ago, a whirlwind romance and he moved in just before they got married.

Now here's the problem. Whatever ID Simon presented at the Registry Office to allow them to get married must have been forged because your friendly local UK government has no record of a passport or driving licence for a Simon Metcalf anywhere near his age. (Don't ask how I know!)

So, if you are thinking that Simon Metcalf is not Simon Metcalf ... take a gold star.'

As Adam finished reading he looked up to see Lorraine Metcalf stand up from her chair in the middle of the lounge.

"Ladies and Gentlemen" she announced "as the eleven of us are forced to stay the night but we are denied the murder-mystery play

we were promised, I would like to invite you all to an after dinner séance. I will be acting as your conduit into the spirit world and I am happy to contact any spirits that might appear for you tonight”

Simon Metcalf jumped like he'd been hit with a cattle prod.

“What?” he exclaimed.

“Yes Simon, I am a psychic medium and who knows, maybe the sad young man from the garden will visit us”

Robert Fallon was obviously the first, and loudest, to speak.

“Well it's all stuff and nonsense of course but it might be a bit of fun. Better than Charades what?”

He cajoled and hectored everyone into agreeing and a time was set for 9pm after dinner.

They were told by the police they wouldn't be needed again that day but some of them might be re-interviewed tomorrow. As they all started to drift back to their rooms Adam asked Finn if he believed in the spirit world.

“Are you kidding? I'm a straightforward numbers guy. It's all logic, and evidence with me. If that stuff is true, show me the proof. Harry Houdini, the great illusionist and escapologist, spent a lifetime debunking these people and he promised that, when he died, if there was any way of sending a message back, he would be in contact. But he never has been.”

“I just think it's sad that gullible people are preyed on by the unscrupulous.” Adam said.

“Well, we'll see. Maybe Lewis Kelly will come back to haunt us.” Finn laughed out loud.

Chapter Eleven

Dinner had been a quiet meal. Adam and Finn had invited James and Anna to eat in their suite. It was a little cramped but they all agreed it was much better than another meal with Fallon. They had claimed that Finn needed to work and Anna developed a sudden migraine. It wasn't convincing but it was enough. It seemed to Adam, during his short explanation, that Fallon was distracted and quite dismissive.

Emily decided to eat alone in her room but had promised to join them for the séance.

"What do you make of all this séance stuff?" James asked.

"Well, personally I think it's a load of old baloney but I'll take it as entertainment rather than anything real" Adam replied.

"It's a bit like watching a magician." Anna joined in. "You know he hasn't sawn a woman in half or produced your card from your own pocket but it's just a bit of fun"

"Well I don't know..." Finn was trying not to smile "You wait until Beelzebub appears from the fiery pit. Then we're all in trouble"

"Try and give Robert a nudge into the pit if you can," said James.

It was a pleasant meal and they all had fun, but at 8.45pm they decided it was time to go downstairs for the entertainment. They called at Emily's door on the way past and she was in good spirits.

"I had a nice nap and this place makes the best smoked salmon sandwiches I've ever tasted." Emily told them.

In the hotel dining room Lorraine Metcalf had organised the staff to put out a huge round table with eleven chairs around it. As people arrived she gestured towards it inviting people to sit where they wanted.

"There are no special seats, no trickery, no 'magic.'" She made air quotation marks to emphasise her point.

When everyone was settled, Lorraine made a brief introduction.

"You are all sitting in places pre-destined by the spirit world. Your choices may, or may not, decide on whether a spirit appears or not. Only the spirits can decide." she told them.

Finn wanted to interrupt and say that made no sense. If the spirits chose, they already knew who would be in touch, but Lorraine left no gaps for interruptions.

She nodded to a waiter behind Finn and Adam who turned off the restaurant lights. The only light was from the warm glow of the candles on the table in front of them. The faces around the tables were now bathed in soft, flickering, light. The effect was atmospheric.

"Close your eyes and join hands" she instructed "Form an unbroken circle. A portal to the afterlife. The spirit world beckons."

Finn wanted to laugh because Lorraine had adopted a spooky, ghostlike voice. He squeezed Adam's hand next to him. Adam squeezed back in unspoken agreement. They were both thinking about the B movie she'd appeared in. Maybe it was really a C movie.

"Ye who are beyond our veil of understanding, we welcome you into our circle. Use our energy and the ring of hands as a portal from your world to ours."

The whole room was deathly quiet. Even Finn would admit it felt unnaturally quiet.

SPIRITS!" Lorraine raised her voice before dropping to a whisper "Join us in our circle. Please make your presence known."

"Are you with us? Do you have a message for us?"

There was silence. An unholy silence, as if the whole world had held its breath. There almost seemed to be a chill in the room.

"I have a visitor" Lorraine whispered "I have someone called Elspeth who would like to talk to her grandson"

"That's me" said Adam "She always believed in the afterlife"

Finn frowned.

"She says... you can, and you should, be more adventurous with the estate" Lorraine still whispered.

"I will" Adam replied "but ask her if she can get Vegan food on the other side. It was a constant worry for her in this life."

"Don't worry..." Lorraine replied. "Everything is perfect on the other side, including for Vegans. She says the food is wonderful and she is very happy indeed"

Lorraine laughed softly as if she was watching a line of children waiting for treats.

"The spirits are eager to contact their loved ones. I have an Elizabeth who wishes to speak to her son"

She didn't wait for a response before continuing.

"What you carry does not outweigh the guilt. You know the right thing to do."

"Does she apologise?" Robert Fallon spoke. He sounded gravelly.

"She does. She knows she was hard on you but thinks it has made you the man you are today. She says she is proud."

Lorraine began to sway in her seat. She hummed, whimpered a little before speaking again. The air felt electric.

"No, I can't... that is horrible..." She sighed "I am channelling great sadness. Not... anger... just sadness and regret."

She paused, her head cocked as if listening. The silence in the room was like a thick blanket. It was the silence of a deep snow drift. A silence that just screamed... silence.

The atmosphere was intense. If a door slams we'll all have a heart attack, thought Finn.

Lorraine spoke quietly. Softly but with urgency, as if conveying a message of great importance.

“There is someone called Mary Benson with us. She tells me that, very sadly, she took her own life. There is someone in the room who bears the responsibility but she won't tell me who. She wants that person to admit it.”

Nobody spoke.

“She thought that would be the case. Too cowardly, even when talking to someone beyond the veil.”

Again, nobody spoke.

“But there's something else, isn't there. Something too awful to contemplate” Lorraine had her eyes closed. She spoke as if to herself. A voice in her head, a message just for her.

“Oh... I see. The spirit of Mary Benson has spoken. She says the only hope of salvation is to atone. To seek redemption by helping someone else achieve peace. Otherwise... eternal damnation awaits.”

Adam looked around the table in the flickering light. Most people had their eyes closed but Lorraine was staring maniacally into the space above Adam's head. Her husband Simon was squeezing his eyes tightly shut and Giles was staring at Finn with a half smile.

He looked around at Finn who had his eyes shut. Adam thought he needed to tell Finn he had a secret admirer.

“The light darkens” Lorraine whispered “The spirits are leaving us. The portal closes.”

Finn opened his eyes and looked around. There was a sense of awakening around the table.

“SPIRITS!” Lorraine called loudly ““We thank you for sharing your guidance with us.”

And with that she slumped forward as if drained.

Everyone took a deep breath, unsure of what to do next. Finn crossed to the doorway and turned on the lights.

"Well that was... intense," he said with a smile.

People started to stand and Anthony Shannon, the cryptocurrency dealer, declared he needed a drink. Several others agreed and there was a move towards the bar.

"Giles, I need to dictate some urgent messages" Robert Fallon said in a loud voice as Giles started to veer towards the bar. Louise Fallon ignored them as if she hadn't heard but headed towards the bar talking to James and Anna.

The Metcalfs followed Fallon and Giles to the lift. Clearly the seance had been tiring for Lorraine but it was Simon who looked like he had seen a ghost.

Walking close to Adam, Finn whispered "Was she a vegan?"

Oh please" said Adam softly. "That woman would have eaten a steak if it was still mooing"

In the bar the conversation naturally turned to the seance. Nobody seemed convinced but they couldn't agree on Lorraine Metcalf's motivation.

"Was it just an entertainment? " asked Louise Fallon "It didn't seem very entertaining"

"Well your husband got a mention" replied Anna.

"Yes, that was interesting but... let's be honest, there were no spirits there. I noticed last night that Mrs Metcalf was straining to listen to all our conversations at dinner. You'd almost think she was preparing for the seance" Louise said with a smile.

"Hah, very observant Louise." Adam laughed. "When we were checking in she was standing close behind us. She couldn't have failed to hear the receptionist ask about Inspector Griffin and James mention my grandmother."

"So no spooky shenanigans or ghostly visits?" said Finn.

"Just a bit of snooping and a theatrical performance" Louise told him
"Although I have no idea who Mary Benson was"

There were negative responses all round "Maybe it's just part of the spectacle?" Anna asked, "As if she was leaving us with a mystery."

Finn had already made a mental note to investigate Mary Benson.

In their room Lorraine Metcalf was studiously ignoring her husband while she started to get ready for bed. She was many things but she wasn't stupid. She had always known Simon was a gold-digger, in fact she intended to use that for her own purposes.

"Lorraine..." Simon said "that was all an act wasn't it?"

"An act? No Simon. Sometimes the spirits are with me and sometimes they aren't. Tonight, for whatever reason, they were there and they matched the people around the circle."

"What do you know?" he asked.

"I only know what I'm told Simon. What do you want to tell me?"

Simon was silent. He was pale, nervous and quite jittery.

"She told me Simon. She has been following you, waiting for a moment to communicate. She told me everything. She told me what you are." Her voice dropped to a whisper "She told me what you did Simon."

He started to shake, the events of the past 24 hours had affected him deeply. Lying to the police, pretending to behave normally and then the seance had put his stress levels through the roof. He was a man on the edge.

"It was an accident. I only meant to scare him off. It all just got out of hand."

Lorraine watched him closely. This wasn't what she was expecting but she waited, allowing him the space to talk. Whatever he was talking about, it could make the next part of her plan much easier.

She had discovered that Simon had bad intentions early on in their relationship. Something in the first month made her stop and think. Then, while he was deep in post-coital sleep, she'd gone through his belongings. Having spent a lot of money on false ID's Simon was loath to destroy them. Lorraine found three previous names, including what she thought might be his real name.

From there it was easy to search online for media reports, birth and marriage records and court appearances. When they got married Lorraine knew exactly what sort of man Simon was and she hoped he was exactly the sort of man she could use.

She waited. Simon wrung his hands, stuttered and appeared close to tears.

"When I hit him, he just fell and I knew immediately it was too much. I'd hit him too hard but, I swear Lorraine, I only wanted to scare him off. He was going to ruin everything Lorraine. He would have spoiled our lives and I couldn't allow that."

Don't you dare say you did it for us, Lorraine thought.

"I threw the hammer in the lake" he said "It was the only thing I touched in there"

Her mind was working overtime. His words sank in as she realised he was the killer.

This was too good to be true. She'd hoped to manipulate Simon using his previous frauds and his plan to rob her but now he'd confessed he'd already committed the ultimate crime. Her plan would give him the perfect alibi.

"Simon..." she said soothingly "don't worry. Mary told me everything. She said you didn't mean to kill him. She was there Simon. She saw everything."

Simon looked up at her. His guilt and the stress meant he was prepared to believe anything at that moment.

"I can give you an alibi Simon. I can make sure they can't tie you to this. Mary told me you were planning to leave me after taking all my

money but... we can have a good life together Simon. I have enough money for us both to have a comfortable life, even a luxury life."

Lorraine was convincing, sincere, heartfelt. Simon thought he had a lifeline. He was drowning, facing a life behind bars, and there was Lorraine with the cell door keys.

"You just have to do just one thing for me," Lorraine whispered.

Simon nodded "Anything."

Chapter Twelve

The next morning Adam looked out of their bedroom window and could see divers in the lake. Obviously they had acted on the memory he and Finn had about the sudden, unexplained 'plop'.

On the phone next to the bed a light flashed indicating a message. Adam picked up the phone and pressed the flashing button. A voice he didn't recognise said:

"The police have requested all guests assemble in the lounge at 9am for further information."

Adam sighed. He suspected there would be precious little information but another round of interviews, cross checking information and looking to add the tiniest details.

He sat on the edge of the bed and reached across to the sleeping Finn. He brushed his hair to one side. Not for the first time he thought how lucky he was to have met Finn. He smiled. Finn was good looking, with a great body, but more importantly he was kind, thoughtful and clever.

Sometimes he could be too clever, too analytical, too logical. It took Adam to crowbar his impulsive side free. Adam would make sure they had spontaneous moments that dragged Finn away from his screens and his work. Finn, Adam had decided long ago, could easily lose himself in his work - and Adam wouldn't allow that to happen.

Finn also had a deeply compassionate side. An empathy that left you feeling that, when you spoke to him, you felt that he really listened as if nothing else mattered. It was a trait that endeared him to people even though he was totally logical and analytical. He had the ability to cut through all the noise and see an issue clearly.

It was Finn that had persuaded Adam to forgive his half-sister even though she had been killed by the police during an attempt on Adam's life. Finn had also persuaded Adam to forgive himself. Even though he had no idea of his half-sister's existence, Adam had felt guilty that he hadn't been able to help her, both financially and emotionally.

Finn roused slightly and let out a quiet grumble.

"The police want everyone downstairs at 9am Finn." Adam said quietly "if you want breakfast you'll need to get up now"

"Have you had a shower yet?" Finn asked sleepily.

"Not yet."

Finn smiled slowly and wagged his eyebrows. "Good, let's skip breakfast and shower together."

Guests started appearing in the lounge. Some had been to breakfast but Adam and Finn appeared with wet hair and big smiles. Finn waved at Emily across the room and they headed in her direction. About the same time James and Anna came out of the restaurant so they all sat together.

"More information?" said James. "Does that mean it's solved?"

"Probably not..." said Adam "more likely another round of interviews"

"I suppose it's always possible it's nobody from the hotel," Finn said "A prowler? A burglar maybe?"

"Yeah, maybe Lewis Kelly just happened to be in the wrong place at the wrong time," Anna said.

"Either way," Emily said glumly "I think I'm still their prime suspect."

Before anyone could reply Detective Inspector Coates and his colleague Detective Sergeant Bill Cross swept into the room like men on a mission. Inspector Coates spoke.

"Ladies and gentlemen, thank you for joining us this morning..."

"Like we had a choice," grumbled Anthony Shannon not very quietly, a few seats away.

"... as the investigation is ongoing my colleague and I intend to re-interview everyone together to make sure we have a full understanding of the case."

Looking to catch someone out thought Finn.

"We will get to all of you quite quickly but, if we may..." Coates sounded reassuring and relaxed, as if it was just a formality. Nobody was a suspect here. "... we would like to start with Mrs Metcalf."

Inevitably Robert Fallon stood and spoke loudly.

"When can we expect to be released from our incarceration Inspector?" he called dramatically. "Some of us have important matters to attend to."

"Weren't you booked into the hotel until tomorrow Mr Fallon?" the Inspector smiled, "if you were expecting to be here, I can't see any compelling reason for you to be elsewhere."

Adam watched as Giles looked away trying to suppress a smile.

"Mrs Metcalf..." Coates gestured to a side room that had been put aside for the interviews.

A few moments later Lorraine Metcalf settled onto a hard chair in front of a desk. Both police officers sat opposite her.

"Do I need a lawyer?" she smiled at them.

"Good grief no, Mrs Metcalf. You're only a witness but if you feel you need a solicitor... we're happy to wait."

Lorraine made a dismissive gesture and smiled thinly.

"What we hope to do this morning is to fill in a few gaps in the timeline to try and establish a sort of who did what and when pattern. That will allow us to eliminate people from our line of investigation." Inspector Coates sounded assuring.

"After dinner..." Sergeant Cross spoke up. "I understand you and your husband went upstairs together"

"No..." Lorraine replied. "As I told the inspector yesterday, I went upstairs and my husband went for a cigarette outside."

"Did you have a pleasant meal?" Cross countered.

Lorraine paused for a moment because the question seemed too mundane and irrelevant.

"The food was fine but we had argued before dinner so I suppose we were both sulking a little," she smiled as if to say 'you know how it is'.

Cross consulted his notes. "How long was it before your husband came upstairs?"

"I don't know how long it takes to smoke a cigarette... five minutes?" she questioned. "I know he came up at 22:28."

"You can be that precise?"

"Yes, because again, as I explained yesterday, he'd been struggling with his Smart watch and had checked the time on reception, via the Internet. He kept saying he couldn't work out if the watch was cleverer than him or more stupid. He was quite irritating really because apparently his watch was still saying the same time the receptionist had told him."

"And how did he seem?" Cross continued.

"As I said, quite irritating. Nothing unusual though. I was in a bad mood, he had been in a bad mood. I think we were just getting on each other's nerves but... it had all passed in the morning."

"And he was with you all night from..." Cross looked down again "...22:28?"

"Yes, sergeant. I am a very light sleeper and the slightest sound or movement wakes me up. So he woke me twice during the night to go to the toilet but apart from that we both slept through the night."

"Thank you Mrs Metcalf" Inspector Coates spoke smoothly "that will be all for now."

Lorraine stood to leave.

"One last thing though..." Coates smiled reassuringly "Did you leave the room during the night?"

Lorraine looked confused for a split second as if it never occurred to her that she would be questioned.

"No, I was in the room from just after ten until the next morning."

She turned to leave but turned back. "One odd thing though. When my husband got up to pee, I thought I heard someone walk past in the corridor. Is that significant?"

"We'll certainly look into that," said Coates, all smiles. Sergeant Cross wrote on his pad.

As she made her way back into the lounge, Lorraine was pleased. She'd established an alibi for her husband and thrown in a red herring to the police to muddy the waters. She needed time for her plan to succeed.

"What do you think of her?" asked Coates when they were alone.

"Well, if they ever reboot 101 Dalmatians I think they should call her for the Cruella De Vil role but most of what she says stacks up." Cross ran his hand through his hair and looked at his notes.

"The thing about the person in the corridor is nonsense, obviously, because we've checked all the movements on the CCTV. So why would she just chuck that in?"

"Maybe she just thought she was being helpful?" Coates said. "Or maybe it's just sleight of hand... smoke and mirrors."

When Simon Metcalf followed his wife, his story matched perfectly. He saw Robert Fallon returning from the smoking shelter on his way out. They had barely exchanged nods and he had no idea if Fallon had been into the shed or not. He had smoked his cigarette on his own and hadn't seen anyone else in or around the shelter.

"Why did you ask the receptionist for the time when you could have looked it up on your phone?" Coates asked him.

Simon faltered. "I... thought I didn't have my phone. I thought it was in the room so it just seemed easier to ask him to look it up on one of those super-accurate web sites."

"and you're not wearing your Smart watch now I notice."

Simon snorted quietly. "No, I've sort of given up with it. Too complicated, but... don't tell the wife!"

As he showed Simon out and closed the door Coates turned to his colleague.

"What do you think Bill?"

"Well... in all fits together but it's making me twitch a bit."

"I know just what you mean," Coates replied. "Did you notice he used the exact words as her? He 'couldn't work out if the watch was cleverer than him or more stupid'. No deviation, even the same tone of voice."

"They might be up to something Guv, but is it murder?"

All the other guests were interviewed during the course of the day. Some staff were brought back in to be interviewed, some locals who had dined that evening, and a couple of delivery drivers who had visited late afternoon.

Mrs Metcalf had been very vocal in dramatically telling everyone in the lounge that her husband had been with her all night. Nobody seemed that interested, although Adam and Finn exchanged a glance.

Emily had been grilled about her relationship with Kelly. She was not to be browbeaten by any questioning and gave straightforward honest answers. She even quizzed the officers about why Kelly had been released from police custody when he should have been back in prison.

The two police officers concluded that she had the best motive but, unless they could work out a means for her to attack Kelly, it seemed unlikely. The corridor CCTV confirmed she was in her room all night and there was no evidence outside of anyone leaving by the window.

Chapter Thirteen

While Emily was being interviewed Adam went across the room to a long table, covered in a white tablecloth. Coffee and tea pots and a plate of biscuits had been laid out for the guests.

As he turned, balancing two cups of coffee and a small plate of chocolate biscuits, he saw Finn watching him from across the room. They locked eyes for a moment and exchanged small smiles.

"I wish someone would look at me like that." Adam looked round and it was Alfie, holding two fresh coffee pots. "He adores you," Alfie continued.

"It's mutual Alfie, but stay with it. You'll find someone."

"Not here. It's like God's waiting room. The only people that can afford to stay here are ancient" he looked at Adam and then grinned broadly "Not you obviously... but generally."

"I'm mortally offended" laughed Adam "aren't we the same age?"

"More or less. I think you're a year older, and that's about a hundred years under the average age here normally."

Alfie thought for a moment. "Do you think I should move to London?"

"London can be a pretty lonely place Alfie. It's not paved with gold. But, either way, make sure you've got a job and somewhere to stay first."

Alfie nodded and moved off with some empty coffee pots. Back with Finn, Adam recounted the conversation. "He's sweet and pretty good looking, I'm sure he'll find someone," Finn said.

"As long as he doesn't want you..." Adam grinned.

After their own interviews, just before lunch, Adam and Finn realised they had skipped breakfast and were both hungry. James and Anna

had to wait so they went for lunch in the restaurant with Emily.

As Emily picked at her food, moving more about the plate than she was actually eating, Adam asked what she was thinking.

"To be honest, I'm somewhere between sad and angry about Lewis. It's like, even now he's dead, he can't stop messing up my life. Obviously I'm sad he's dead but..." her voice trailed off.

"You can't rewind what has happened Emily," Finn told her. "You can only process what is factual and logical. Lewis Kelly was obsessed, to the extent that, for whatever reason, he died. None of that is your fault. If it wasn't you, it would have been someone else. If it wasn't here it might have been somewhere else. Once this is resolved, and it will be, Lewis Kelly is no longer part of your life and no cause for anxiety."

"I suppose so... it's just sad that I thought we were so happy at the beginning." She sighed "I think I'll give up men and become a nun."

After lunch Finn and Adam took possession of Finn's perfectly secluded corner in the lounge. Finn took out his laptop and started investigating Mary Benson.

He didn't know why but something told him she was significant. Something was irritating the back of his brain. Something was telling him she might be a key.

It took him moments to uncover a story about a rich widow who had fallen in love with a conman - a romance scammer - who had fleeced her for large sums of money and property.

The tragic tale would have had a happy ending because the conman, who had illegally married Mary Benson, was caught leaving the country. It made the national media because the conman had made a run for it and the subsequent chase through the airport had been captured in several viral videos from bystanders. People who were more interested in filming than helping to stop a fleeing criminal.

Mary thought she had found love at a time of life when she wanted, almost craved, companionship and the joy of a shared life.

On the day the conman was convicted, despite having got all of her money back, Mary took an overdose of sleeping pills and died alone.

Finn was sad as he relayed the story to Adam next to him. Adam could read the story over Finn's shoulder and they held hands for a moment in a quiet tribute to Mary, whose life should not have ended.

Despite the national coverage there was surprisingly little about the conman, whose name was Philip Clarke. All the airport footage was pre-trial so faces were pixilated for privacy. Very little background information on the conman except his previous convictions.

It took Finn a little while to find a grainy photo online from a tiny local Hampshire newspaper. Philip Clarke, it turned out, was a local boy and the poor image showed him in his late teens or early 20's

Finn nudged Adam, who was looking at his own phone. They both stared at Finn's screen, then back at each other.

Philip Clarke was Simon Metcalf. Unmistakably - even in a grainy low-resolution photo.

"So... why would Lorraine bring up Mary Benson" whispered Adam.

"I don't know, but Lorraine is quite well off so... maybe she's Simon's next target?"

"Why would she marry him if she knew his past?" Finn continued.

"Could she have blackmailed Simon?" Adam asked quietly.

"Into murder?"

They bounced some ideas and scenarios around but nothing stood out other than the oddity of Lorraine and her impromptu seance.

"I could access police and prison records to establish a link between Lorraine and Lewis Kelly... or maybe Simon, but I can't do it from here. It's too dangerous and I don't have the right tools with me to cover my tracks." Finn said, his mind working overtime.

"No, obviously not. Let the police uncover that stuff but for the moment let's keep all this under our hat. Maybe we can try and find out something more concrete."

Later, as the police left promising to release everyone the next morning, Adam arranged to take over the meeting room they had used and organised delivery of several large pizzas. A waiter brought beer and wine and the five of them spent an enjoyable evening.

The conversation flowed but everyone was avoiding the elephant in the room. Everyone is thinking about the murder but nobody wants to talk about it.

Adam and Finn had fun but they were both aware that the other was mulling possibilities. Sifting information, hoping to find that one speck of gold that would unlock the mystery.

What did Lorraine want from Simon? Is there a link from her to Kelly? If Simon killed Lewis Kelly, that would give her a huge amount of leverage. He would have to do whatever she wanted. But, what did she want?

Or was it all a massive coincidence. Could the murder just be a random attack by a prowler? Every scenario pointed to the Metcalfs, either him or her, unless that was too obvious.

Chapter Fourteen

After pizza and a couple of drinks people started drifting off. Emily said she needed an early night and James and Anna had a glint in their eyes.

It was only about 10.30pm but Adam said, "do you know what? I think I'll go to bed too. I've got some reports to read that will probably put me to sleep in minutes"

"I'll come up and get my bag and then slip into my cosy corner" Finn replied.

"I still can't understand how you manage on so little sleep but still look gorgeous" Adam smiled. He ran the back of his hand down Finn's chest.

Back in the lobby Finn had set up his laptop on a small table. The chair wasn't the most comfortable but it was fine for working. In some ways Finn thought it was a good thing to have an uncomfortable chair. It made him concentrate on his work, rather than get distracted by the Internet... or murder.

Finn was pleased to be shielded by plants and furniture as he heard Robert Fallon walk past to go outside for his evening cigar. He really couldn't think of anything worse than a conversation with Fallon just now. Perhaps it was fortunate that Fallon considered him insignificant.

Fallon was full of bluster and self-importance as he lumbered through the hotel, even though only the receptionist was there to see him. Finn thought it was almost like he wanted to let Alfie know that his cigar costs a fortune.

"He knows the price of everything and the value of nothing," Finn said out loud to himself quietly. He laughed at himself. He wasn't normally one to quote Oscar Wilde and he surprised himself

because he had no idea how he knew that. It seemed appropriate though.

With Fallon gone the hotel seemed to relax into a quiet mood. Obviously the events of the day had made everyone tired enough to retire to bed early. Finn checked through some work emails, replied to most and then opened a project file for an engineering company in Germany that suspected they were losing sensitive commercial data. Finn's job was to try and breach their security and then report on how to fix it.

Upstairs, Lorraine Metcalf watched as a hand appeared over the frame of her open window. She crossed the room quickly and reached right down outside to grab the belt of Simon's trousers. Between them they managed to haul him back into the room.

Lorraine pulled up the length of knotted nylon rope that Simon had managed to climb. Down and then back up.

"Did you get it?" she asked urgently.

"Lorraine... it was awful..."

"Yes, yes... but did you get it?"

In response Simon pulled something from his pocket and held it out.

It was a rose gold Patek Philippe made around 1905 with a cover and a gold chain. Almost unnoticeable, there was a small USB drive attached to the watch.

Lorraine didn't take the watch from him. "It was my father's watch Simon and Fallon stole it from him nearly 30 years ago," she explained. "I've tried everything to get it back. This was the only solution." Lorraine started to falter, her voice broke. "It was worth nothing to him, maybe a couple of thousand, but it was the only link I had with my father."

Simon watched as a tear ran down her cheek. He looked shell shocked. "Lorraine... I could have just..."

"No Simon" she interrupted. "This was the only way because now we are free. Free to enjoy the rest of our lives together."

She took control and held out a plastic bag. "Drop the watch in here and I'll hide it in my suitcase" she told him.

She made Simon strip all his clothes off. "Get in the shower and I'll check all your clothes for blood or other evidence. And have a really long shower, I want you to wash everywhere at least three times and don't come out for at least 15 minutes."

Simon stepped into the shower and let the warm water run over his hair and body. Deep down, he knew the last half an hour would haunt him for the rest of his life but he felt compelled. Without Lorraine confirming his alibi he would be in prison for murdering Kelly. One impulsive move, one wild swing of a hammer and his life was over.

It didn't occur once to Simon that Kelly's life was over in a much more permanent way.

Lorraine pulled a pair of latex gloves from her handbag and worked quickly. Opening her suitcase she pulled out a tightly folded plastic bag and messily stuffed all Simon's clothes inside. She switched the USB drive for an identical drive that she took from her case.

She took the original drive and put it into a small plastic anti-static bag. She had read online that it would help protect any data from corruption, and she hoped that was true. Then she put it into a larger, padded envelope. Pre-addressed and ready to go.

"Bingo," she whispered to herself.

As she crossed the room she listened at the bathroom door. She could hear Simon crying above the sound of the shower.

"Hmm..." she said quietly "but you were happy to defraud vulnerable women weren't you?"

She closed the hotel room door quietly behind her.

Finn was concentrating in front of his laptop. Pretty good security, he thought to himself. A flash of movement and two voices broke his attention.

Lorraine and Alfie were talking at the reception desk and Finn watched as Lorraine handed over a small padded envelope. Then she handed Alfie some folded banknotes and held his hand a few seconds too long. She smiled, Alfie smiled. It all looked innocent and straightforward but... nothing this weekend had been normal and Lorraine was as far from straightforward. She might also be a long way from innocent.

Finn was intrigued.

A few minutes later Finn went over to chat to Alfie.

"How come you're still here after eleven Alfie?" he asked.

"Hah!" Alfie laughed. "It's such a great deal. The normal night receptionist is 'sick'." Alfie made quotation marks in the air with his fingers. "Truth is, he's probably passed out with the drink somewhere. So, the general manager asked me to stay on. I said I couldn't because I had plans, so his only option was to come in and cover it himself. I offered to do it for triple time because I'd have to cancel my plans for tonight and tomorrow."

"Is there anything to do around here at 11pm?" Finn asked him.

Alfie just grinned. "Not really but now I expect to sleep most of the night on the sofa in the office like he normally does."

As they chatted Finn could see, upside down, that the address was an address in Surrey. He memorised the address to look up later. Finn recognised the company name as a postbox service that does courier drop off points because most couriers will not deliver to a PO Box.

"I saw Mrs Metcalf drop that package off," Finn said.

Alfie looked a little bit sheepish but said it was, apparently, a surprise present for her husband and she wanted to get it collected before he noticed it in her suitcase.

"And she paid for the courier?"

"Yes... why?" Alfie asked warily.

"It's just that couriers don't normally accept cash so it looks like she gave you a bribe to keep quiet."

"Well it's just a surprise for her husband..." Alfie was sounding unsure now.

"Look Alfie, Adam and I have been looking into Mr & Mrs Metcalf and neither of them are completely legitimate. I don't know what's going on but I'd hate you to get dragged in."

Finn knew he was manipulating Alfie but didn't feel bad about it. This could be a big clue - otherwise, why all the cloak and dagger about late night visits to the lobby?

Finn told Alfie that he believed there might be something illegal in the padded envelope.

"I have a scanner attached to my laptop that would tell us if there were drugs or something else illegal without even opening the envelope." Finn was making it up but he sounded convincing.

"I could lose my job," Alfie said.

"I will make sure that won't happen," said Finn reassuringly, "do you have anything to do in the back office for a few minutes?"

"I have to prepare a morning newspaper list for guests and breakfast orders for anyone who wants it in their room," Alfie sounded unsure. "It would only take about 5 minutes because there are so few people here."

"Perfect." Finn grinned at him as if they were co-conspirators.

Finn took the envelope from behind the desk when Alfie went into the office and crossed back to his seat. He could feel something small and hard inside so he took a small craft knife and a glue stick from his laptop bag. Adam had always laughed at the rubbish Finn carried around in his bag. He'd told Finn he could probably fix a broken down car, then produce a buffet lunch for the driver.

Starting at the bottom, away from the end that you would normally seal down, Finn prised open a small hole in the seam. It's just enough to slide out a small plastic bag containing a USB drive.

Finn recognises it immediately. It's an older type, not that sleek and modern. It's exactly the same type as he saw on Robert Fallon's watch chain.

Taking great care, and a microfibre cloth from his bag, Finn unsealed the plastic bag and inserted the drive into his laptop. His laptop had a self-designed feature that enabled him to put any device into his machine without fear of malware or viruses. The technical term was a sandbox and Finn had used it many times to isolate potentially hazardous items.

He scanned down the file list. His mouth opened.

"Oh my God..." he whispered to himself "That's... unbelievable..."

In among the files on the drive Finn noted a couple of image files that were screenshots of another system.

"Oh, for fuck's sake. This just gets worse."

He quickly slipped the USB drive into his pocket. He took an empty USB drive from his bag and resealed the envelope. The intrusion was undetectable to the casual observer.

Finn needed to talk to Adam. He needed to wake Adam up and tell him everything. Somebody needed to make sense of this. Finn's brain was pinging off in a dozen directions and only Adam could help him focus.

He left the envelope on the desk and called out to Alfie in the back office "All clear. Nothing dodgy at all."

Adam liked to get a full night's sleep but something in the urgency of Finn's voice jolted him awake instantly.

"Wait..." he said, sitting up in bed and blinking in the light. "Let me get dressed and we'll walk around the lake. The night air will wake me up and you can tell me everything."

Finn hopped from foot to foot while Adam dressed but remained quiet. He wanted Adam to be fully alert as he unfolded the story.

They walked downstairs and out of the main doors. Alfie was nowhere in sight. Probably asleep on triple time by now, thought Finn.

He took a deep breath and started to tell Adam about the strange behaviour of Lorraine Metcalf and her midnight visit to the reception desk.

"Stop..." said Adam quietly and grabbed Finn's arm, stopping him mid-stride.

Adam sniffed the air like a nocturnal animal. Finn had experienced Adam's extraordinary sense of smell before. He'd often told Adam he must have more scent receptors than a bloodhound.

"It's... something metallic... like old coins," Adam said to himself.

He turned and faced Finn full on. "I can smell blood," he whispered.

Without discussion they both pulled out their phones and turned on their torches. They scanned the immediate area, including under their feet. They both moved towards the lake and Adam said the smell got stronger.

"An animal?" asked Finn.

Before Adam could answer they took a step forward and a motion activated light came on in the smoking shelter. There, in the harsh, cold light, a body was lying on its back, completely motionless.

Neither of them needed to confirm it was Robert Fallon. His sheer bulk gave that away.

"Whoa... that's a lot of blood. I'll go in from the shallow end," Finn said with a gallows humour that sounded harsh and unfeeling.

"I don't think you need to go any closer" Adam said "With this much blood loss I don't think you need to confirm whether he's dead or not"

They spent a moment taking in the horrific scene. Fallon had been stabbed in the chest once and had a wide slice in his neck that had severed an artery.

"He must have died pretty quickly," Finn said. "I didn't like him but I don't think he deserved this, the poor man."

Adam looked down, next to the body and saw Fallon's expensive cigar still slightly aglow next to him. He switched his phone to camera and took a couple of images of it.

"Maybe the length of the cigar will help them judge the time he was attacked." he told Finn.

"We need to wake up Alfie and ring the police," Finn told him.

As they walked back to the hotel Finn realised he hadn't managed to tell Adam his discoveries from earlier. The latest discovery added another layer so he decided to wait until the police had interviewed them and they were in bed before they talked.

"Just say you couldn't sleep, and I never sleep, so we decided to go for a walk," he told Adam.

Adam just nodded. "The games afoot..." he said out loud.

"Sherlock Holmes?" Finn asked.

"Henry the Fifth... but, either way, there's murky goings-on tonight"

Chapter Fifteen

Dawn crept in rather than broke. It was a crisp, spring morning as dozens of police officers, paramedics and forensic scientists went about their daily business.

Police tape cordoned off a large area outside with junior officers positioned to keep out unwanted gawkers. Forensic officers moved back and forth, measuring and documenting the entire scene. For them it was just another day. An event to record and analyse in a clinical, objective way. It was rare for them to be emotionally affected.

Sergeant Bill Cross had been one of the first on the scene after receiving a call in the early hours of the morning because he lived fairly close by. After 25 years of marriage Bill Cross loved his wife and two sons. He certainly didn't intend to wake the whole household because he had been called into work.

As he finished dressing his sleepy wife said quietly, "Be careful Bill. Come home safe."

He kissed two of his fingers audibly and gently touched her nose. She smiled, still half asleep. He poked his head around the doors of his sons' bedrooms shaking his head at the chaotic mess that, apparently, all teenage boys inhabit. He took a games controller from his younger son's hand and switched off a screen. Not for the first time he resolved to cut off Internet access at 10pm but realised it was a battle he would probably lose. Then he left the house for the murder scene.

The universe was in a playful, slightly vindictive, mood when it decided to make Bill Cross a murder investigator.

Sergeant Cross was, at best, uncomfortable with crime scenes. He hated to see blood and gore. He wouldn't even watch horror films.

While he would happily pore over crime scene photos afterwards, being at the actual event made him feel queasy and a little nauseous. He was a thorough and successful detective but preferred the abstract, and the detachment that came after the body had been removed.

Unlike TV detectives Bill Cross had never been present during a post-mortem. Despite knowing a huge amount about pathology and forensic science he knew the 'blood and guts' end of the procedure was not for him.

After his initial viewing of the site he had supervised the first officers on the scene, moving the cordon back to include the entire path back to the hotel. A white tent was erected over the supine body of Robert Fallon and somehow that made Cross feel better.

Sometimes he liked to pretend his uneasiness was connected to the dignity of the deceased. As if he was intruding. Staring and ogling like a tourist. Taking away their last vestige of propriety. Deep down, and barely acknowledged, Bill Cross knew he was just squeamish.

He had spoken to Adam and Finn when he arrived, immediately after viewing the scene.

"I'll want to talk to you again this morning and then a formal interview when we know some more facts." he told them.

So far, Cross had established that Fallon had gone for his evening cigar, witnessed by the receptionist and by Finn. Nobody had seen him return but that was no cause for alarm bells because either of them could have simply missed him passing.

The alarm was raised later when Adam and Finn had gone for a stroll around the lake and discovered the body.

Cross had decided there was nothing suspicious about a midnight walk because he already knew Finn's strange sleeping pattern from their previous interviews and lots of people go for a walk if they can't sleep.

So far, nobody had told Cross about Lorraine Metcalf's visit to reception. The shock of another murder had temporarily pushed it out of Alfie's mind and Finn had too many unanswered questions of his own.

It seemed to Finn that CCTV would uncover that, and that gave him time to think.

Detective Inspector Alan Coates arrived looking freshly shaved and showered. He made Cross look even more dishevelled. Cross looked like he had fallen out of bed and got dressed in the dark. Because he had.

Maybe he should adopt a more relaxed view of murder enquiries. Maybe that's the key to promotion, he thought.

"So what have we got so far Bill?" Coates asked.

"Well... subject to the pathologist's report, it looks like the assailant struck from behind and slashed the victim's throat. No evidence of a struggle really but there is a lot of blood. There's also a single stab wound to the chest but I would guesstimate that was after the neck. Maybe on the ground, maybe on the way down."

"It's all too coincidental to be random so we can probably rule out a burglar or stalker," Coates added.

"The obvious answer is that Emily Morgan murdered Lewis Kelly, on impulse possibly, because Kelly was threatening her and she was literally in fear of her life. Later, she realised that Fallon had gone for a cigar and had witnessed the murder. So, she decided, in her stressed state, that the best solution was to get rid of the witness."

Sergeant Cross sounded sceptical even as he was saying it out loud.

"I mean..." he continued, "it's possible but seems highly unlikely. I didn't even fancy her for the first death."

"No, you're right but I think we'll interview her again. More formally this time, just to be certain"

"Hopefully we'll get some forensics back on the first case today, that might give us a heads-up"

"What about the two who discovered the body? Any thoughts on them?"

"For the deaths? No opportunity, no motive... other than the fact that they have met Mr Fallon. Just meeting him seems like a motive for any of us." Cross smiled grimly.

"Yes, but he apparently has friends in high places. I've already fielded a call from the Chief Constable and our illustrious member of parliament this morning. Everybody and his dog wants to interfere today."

Sunday morning was unfolding slowly. The padded envelope sat in a tray behind the reception desk. No courier would be allowed in today. The envelope would just sit there, until all this commotion passed and then a courier would arrive to collect it.

The few guests that were in the hotel were coming down to breakfast to hear the news. Adam had spoken to James, Anna and Emily to break the news, rather than leaving them to wander down later to a barrage of police activity.

Louise Fallon had been told last night and was currently in her room with a specially trained police officer. She'd told the police that she had taken some painkillers and gone to bed. She had not realised he hadn't come back to the room and, if she had, she would have assumed he was working on something with Giles.

Finn and Adam were sitting in the lounge area talking quietly. They were both tired but their brains were on fast-forward.

"Did we let that happen to Fallon?" Adam asked. "If we had gone to the police earlier..."

"Don't beat yourself up Adam." Finn reassured him. "We had suspicions, but so did the police. By the time we found out something more concrete, Fallon was already dead."

"I'm sure you're right but even so... even with how obnoxious he was... he didn't deserve this"

"Not based on what we know but there are still parts of the jigsaw missing. I've got a plan for that though." Finn was looking across the lobby to the slender figure of Giles heading their way. He looked pale and tired.

"I'm sorry Giles" Finn said as Giles arrived.

Giles held up a hand. "To be honest, I'm not sad at all. Even though I'll lose my home and job I really can't muster up any sadness"

"Don't let the police hear you saying that" Adam told him. "They might think you killed him"

Before Giles could respond Finn said "Did you kill him Giles?"

"Oh good God no. I mean, most people knew I despised him but I hated the way he made me feel about myself even more than that. He was such a manipulator and seemed to relish making others feel bad. Maybe he just manipulated the wrong person?"

Adam took a long look at Giles. His instinct told him that Giles wasn't the murderous sort but there was something Giles wasn't saying.

"I can feel a 'but' coming Giles" he said.

Giles looked at Finn. "I know you're a bit of a computer whizz and the police have taken Mr Fallon's laptop, but there are some photos online that are... embarrassing."

"What do you mean by 'online' Giles"

"Mr Fallon had some sort of storage space in the cloud, all connected to his email account I believe."

"And are these photos of you Giles?" Adam asked.

Giles looked sheepish. It was clear that there were explicit images and Giles would be very embarrassed if they became public.

"OK, Giles. What I'm about to tell you should remain between us and you can't discuss it with anyone... ever." Finn looked straight at Giles, fixing him with a serious gaze.

"Adam and I have unearthed some information that we will be handing over to the police but we'd both like to give them the whole jigsaw rather than a half-completed picture."

"And..." Giles strung out the word cautiously.

"And..." Finn repeated. "I can make those images disappear from the cloud. There will be no evidence they existed or who deleted them. I can also track down any copies that Fallon might have distributed and delete those too."

"Is that even possible?" said Giles "Supposing he's sent them to dozens of people?"

"Well, I can only track those with some help from you," Finn replied. "I need access to Fallon's email and I'm willing to bet you have the password."

"I do, but..."

"It's a trade-off, Giles. We can help you, but we want to solve this riddle quickly so that our friend isn't the prime suspect any more."

Adam nodded encouragingly. As soon as Finn mentioned email he realised the direction Finn was moving. Robert Fallon wasn't the sort to have elaborate security or encrypted messages. A simple password would open up a wealth of information.

Giles just nodded once. "I'm even ashamed of you seeing the images"

"Giles, I give you my word I will destroy every photo of you I can find and do my best to track any others down."

"And, believe me Giles," Adam added "Finn is the best in the world at this stuff. He will help you."

Giles nodded again. He took a deep breath and, as his chest inflated, his shoulders straightened and moved back. Giles instantly

looked relieved, more confident and assertive. The brow-beaten Giles seemed to shrink away and something more upbeat appeared. He told Finn the user-name and password.

"Give us an hour," Finn smiled.

As Giles left they could see Detective Sergeant Cross heading their way.

"We seem disturbingly popular at the moment" said Finn.

"That's what happens when you find a dead body I suppose," said Adam softly.

Cross seemed to be living up to his name. Not really with them, just with life in general. Like Finn and Adam, he had been awake too long, missed too much sleep and generally felt cranky.

"We will need to formally interview you again shortly. It might be under caution"

"Do we need a solicitor?" Adam asked.

"Would it help if I rang my Dad?" Finn chimed in.

"And who would he be?"

"He's Detective Chief Inspector Williams, head of the Cyber Crime Division at Scotland Yard"

The policeman looked slightly rattled but continued.

"I don't care who your Dad is. You two are, at best, eye witnesses to a murder and possibly more..."

"Technically..." James said, who had arrived unnoticed. "They aren't eye witnesses, they're key witnesses. They didn't see the murder, they just discovered the body"

"Thank you sir. It's been a long night but I don't need a lecture on police terminology." The policeman was not impressed by this new intrusion.

James ignored him and spoke directly to Adam and Finn. "Would it help if I called my Mum?"

“Oh, and I suppose your mother is the Commissioner of Police is she?” the policeman said tetchily.

“No sir, she’s the Prime Minister”

Detective Sergeant Cross existed in that jaded netherworld – too old for youthful enthusiasm but too young to start counting pay-days until retirement. Part of him was impressed but the main part of him just accepted the stupid inevitability of it all.

Of course she is, he thought. Why not? Next thing will be the Pope arriving.

Chapter Sixteen

Emily sat opposite the two police officers in the hotel meeting room that had been set aside for interviews. It wasn't the first time but somehow this felt different. Less like information gathering and more accusatory. Without saying anything the officers' body language seemed more combative.

And Emily was ready for them. Quite prepared to fight her corner.

"OK, shall we get started?" Inspector Coates said.

Emily nodded but didn't speak.

"Emily Morgan..." Bill Cross spoke now. "You are being interviewed in connection to the deaths of Lewis Kelly and Robert Fallon. You do not have to say anything. But, it may harm your defence if you do not mention, when questioned, something which you later rely on in court. Anything you do say may be given in evidence."

Halfway through his caution the door opened behind them and a woman entered. She was wearing a tailored grey suit and carried a small leather case.

"Very well recited officer but I am the legal representative for Ms Morgan and I would like ten minutes alone to consult with my client before we continue."

"And you are...?" Inspector Coates asked.

The woman looked directly at Emily when she replied.

"My name is Alice Cooper... I know, don't worry, I hate my parents too. I will be your legal counsel and we'll deal with this nonsense in a jiffy."

Turning to the police officers, she continued.

"I also represent Finn Williams, Adam Griffin, James Brand and Anna Chubb and you will not interview any of them unless I am

present."

She smiled at Emily and exuded an air of calm confidence. Back to the police officers she said.

"During the next ten minutes while we confer, I'd like you to prepare some answers for me. I realise Emily will be a suspect, given her relationship with Kelly, and I assume you think Fallon may have witnessed the first murder. So, perhaps you could explain your theories on the wildly different methods?"

Inspector Coates started to speak but she continued.

"Why not bludgeon Mr Fallon the same way as Kelly, and where did Emily get a huge kitchen knife? I've just come through the kitchens so I know that nothing is missing from there – and chefs guard their own knives ferociously. So... how? And, where is it now?"

"I understand you have recovered the CCTV from the corridor outside her room. Doesn't that confirm she never left her room? Has there been a forensic examination of the area outside her window to see if she escaped unnoticed? Does the window even open? Have you checked?"

"And lastly gentlemen. How would she have known Kelly was in the area? Perhaps more importantly, why was Kelly released in the first place?"

Alice Cooper smiled at the officers and started to undo her briefcase. It was clear they were dismissed. The whirlwind abated but they were in no doubt that she would be asking them more difficult questions than they had prepared for Emily.

"Emily, when these chaps have gone, we can get down to details." She looked at the two men, almost defying them to stay.

Now in her mid thirties Alice Cooper was a legal prodigy. With a law degree and post-graduate Masters from Oxford she had been described in the serious media as the finest legal mind of her generation. As soon as she qualified she had law firms queuing with offers. A glittering career stretched ahead of her.

That wasn't always the case.

Alice was brought up in a squalid one bedroom flat in a south London tower block. Less than ten years old the block already suffered problems with rats and cockroaches. Using the lifts was like a game of Russian Roulette because of frequent breakdowns and the smell of urine was ever present.

If the nineties Britain had Docklands redevelopment, Gentrification, prosperity and 'Cool Britannia' - none of that reached Alice's tower block.

Growing up she often wondered what kept her parents together. Her conclusion was that her mother had created some sort of self delusion that her husband was keeping them safe with a roof over their heads.

The reality was a lot different. Her father, Paul Cooper, was barely a teenager when he started recreational drug use. Regular use led to dependency. Dependency led to petty crime and dealing. At twenty Paul Cooper was a heroin addict, small time dealer, shoplifter and bag snatcher.

He met Alice's mother at a party and to everyone's surprise she became pregnant almost immediately. They had laughed because they both believed the old wives tale that you couldn't get pregnant if you had sex standing up.

Alice's mother was called Gina and she insisted they get married as soon as she realised she was pregnant. Her mistaken belief was that if they were married and she had a baby they would be first in line for public housing.

They ended up in a dreadful 'hotel' for the homeless and Alice was nearly two before they moved to the tower block.

It was in the 'hotel' that Paul was persuaded by his cronies to call his child Alice Cooper 'for a laugh'.

Gina Cooper was treated like a doormat by her husband. Somehow she avoided all the drugs but she couldn't escape the abuse, both

physical and emotional. Gina carried scars. Some visible, most not. Her greatest achievement was to protect Alice, sometimes by putting herself in the line of fire but mostly by deflecting and placating her husband.

School was the salvation for Alice. From the very first day she settled into the role of star pupil. She might have been dressed in shabby, second-hand clothes but Alice was bright, enthusiastic and eager. She took to education with an almost evangelical zeal. Nothing escaped her attention. She devoured all subjects with glee. She might not have been much of an artist but anything academic became her passion.

When she was twelve her class had a lesson on parliament and how laws were created. Her instant grasp of the concepts surprised her teacher. Virtually ignoring the rest of the class they had a conversation about the law - why it existed, for whose benefit and how it should be implemented.

The teacher, Miss Bosworth, was an older woman who would become Alice's mentor for the next five years until Alice left for university. Miss Bosworth had a degree in law herself but had opted for a career in teaching. She had a clear and concise way of teaching that fitted perfectly with Alice's analytical mind. Towards the end of Alice's school career, when Alice was taking her Advanced level exams a year early, Miss Bosworth remarked that Alice was already making degree level connections and conclusions. The law, Miss Bosworth announced, needed Alice. Alice already knew that the law would be her escape plan.

Something else happened when Alice was twelve. A domestic dispute at home led to the police visiting her flat. Back in the nineties domestic disputes were given low-priority by the police in London. It was considered, often rightly, that it was a lose-lose situation for the police with women unwilling to press charges and often joining their husbands in attacking the police officers.

Paul Cooper had been particularly aggressive that day and the ensuing fight and shouting had been reported by the neighbours.

Gina Cooper was bleeding and bruised when two police officers turned up and Paul was almost incoherently high. The sight of the officers tending to his wife set Paul off on another rant and he soon started to behave aggressively towards everyone in the room. His wife, his daughter and the two young officers.

Despite attempts at calming him Paul continued to escalate until he swung a fist at a policeman.

The young constable was only twenty one and was fresh from university and the training college at Hendon. He took a punch to the side of the head as Paul tried to push past to attack his wife and daughter again. Almost with a small smile the policeman subdued Paul and put him face down on the floor. It might have been a little more extreme than the restraint methods he'd been shown in training but it did the job.

Later the policeman turned up at the hospital after his shift ended. Alice was waiting for her Mum to be released after treatment and the officer sat and chatted with her. Fortunately Paul Cooper was charged with 'Assaulting a Police Officer' so there was no question of Gina having to decide to prosecute but they all knew Paul would be taken back into their lives.

While they waited and talked it turned out that the policeman was doing a part-time post-graduate degree - a Masters in Criminal Law. During the intense questioning Alice put him through, it transpired that he had a volunteer mentor from the university - Miss Bosworth.

It was the first time Alice had met Marc Williams but they had stayed in touch ever since as long-distance friends. It was Marc who suggested aiming for Oxford. Marc who gave her contacts and helped with her application. It's a sad fact that children with an expensive education at a private school stand a much better chance of getting into the top universities like Oxford and Cambridge. They are simply coached better and have better contacts.

Although not privately educated it was Marc who conjured up a friend who taught at a prestigious school, who helped with the

application and interview process. Miss Bosworth, not to be outdone, introduced Alice to an Emeritus Professor of Law at Oxford who, after meeting Alice several times, provided a personal recommendation.

Alice didn't let any of them down.

Much as she valued Marc's friendship while she was at school, she never had a crush on him. She instinctively knew that she wasn't 'his type' even if she didn't have a word for it. Their friendship was slightly distant, only revolving round the law and their careers. It was never going to be dinner parties and holidays together.

As the door closed Alice smiled at Emily "Honestly I have no idea why they are doing this. They stand more chance of pinning it on the hotel cat"

Alice proceeded to lay out the facts as she understood them with Emily just filling in some small details.

"How do you know all this stuff if you've only just arrived?" Emily asked, looking baffled.

"It's my job to appear with all the right information ready to go but, if you promise not to tell anyone my secret..."

Emily held up three fingers "Guides honour."

Alice grinned. "A lot of it is bullshit. I know they would have checked the CCTV so they have you in your room for the first murder. Naturally then, they would have checked the windows and the window ledges. So, if they had anything more tangible they would have already charged you. So, a bit of supposition and... a bit of inside info from a friend on the force."

Emily shook her head slowly "So they were just... fishing?"

"My best guess is that they are just crossing t's and dotting i's. Giving everything a good shake in case anything odd falls out. Either way, in about ten minutes we'll have you out of here and on your way home."

"I'm with some people so I'll wait for them."

"OK, but tell me. Is that James Brand as in... Margaret Brand?"

"Yep, 'fraid so. I think the police have only just made the connection and, to be honest, I'm surprised a protection squad hasn't swooped in to whisk him off."

Alice laughed "That, or the Attorney General popping down to take my job"

Back in the lounge Finn had set up his laptop in his now familiar place. He and Adam talked quietly and decided they would deal with Giles' photos first. The email may or may not yield something worthwhile but they both felt it was important to help Giles first, before the police gained access.

Chapter Seventeen

"Is this legal?" Adam asked.

"Not in the slightest" Finn answered cheerfully. "But, let's be honest, in the highly unlikely event they trace it back to me, any subsequent court case would have to examine where I learnt these skills. So, somewhere between the government and the intelligence services paperwork would be lost. Evidence would be misfiled. The chain of evidence would mysteriously break down."

"Why would I ever doubt you?" Adam laughed.

Finn created links through various servers, creating private networks inside private networks, bouncing around some countries with very lax rules about paper trails. When he was happy he easily opened up Robert Fallon's cloud storage server.

What they found were lots of photos of Giles in various unpleasant poses and positions. They all showed various degrees of degradation and humiliation. They weren't even sexual photos, they had no real physical bond. They weren't gay in either the modern sense or the happy original meaning. There wasn't a single photo where Giles looked at ease.

It was clear that Robert Fallon enjoyed the discomfort and shame of other people. There were a couple of other young men in the collection and they thought that maybe Fallon had exchanged 'trophies' with people with similar tastes.

Finn thought about him and Adam and how their physical relationship was equal, happy and full of joy and laughter. Giles had none of this. He'd been a desperate, virtually homeless, teenager when he'd been taken in by Fallon. Groomed and coerced by a fear of abandonment and then trapped, possibly even blackmailed into staying.

"Suddenly I don't feel sorry for Fallon any more," Adam whispered to Finn.

"Don't tell Giles but I'm going to copy all these before I delete them so I can track down any copies or evidence that Fallon has distributed them to other people. Especially the ones that aren't Giles."

Adam placed his hand on Finns arm "It would be good if you could destroy any copies but... it would be good to find out who else is involved and tip-off a friendly police officer."

Finn nodded "Go and find Giles, tell him it's done then we'll check the emails."

Adam crossed to the other side of the hotel and, out of sight, he could see Louise Fallon and Giles sitting together on a sofa. He watched for a moment as they talked quietly. They looked... happy. No, not happy. They looked relieved. They both had an air of release about them, as if a great weight had been lifted.

Adam gestured to Giles who jumped up and walked over.

"Finn says the images are gone forever" he told Giles. "Even if the police can persuade a giant US tech company to try and recover the images, which is highly unlikely, they are gone forever. He'll also track down any copies and destroy them."

"Thank you so much Adam..." Giles started to speak but suddenly looked down as if deflated. "Did you look at them?" he asked quietly.

"We did Giles, to make sure we had them all. It was sad Giles because you deserve better."

"I just don't understand how I let..."

Adam interrupted him by putting a hand on Giles' shoulder. "Like I said Giles, you deserve better and you certainly aren't the first person to make a mistake."

Back in their hideaway Adam could see Finn was looking happy.

"I already know who one of the other guys is - or at least his 'employer'. It looks like he has a similar deal to Giles. Fallon has been exchanging emails with him describing some fantasy scenarios"

"It sounds horrific" Adam said "what else?"

Adam watched as Finn scrolled through pages of emails. For a man who claimed to be technophobic, Robert Fallon was a prodigious emailer. As the subject lines whizzed past Adam could almost sense Finn instantly assessing each line.

There were politicians, Archbishops, millionaires, billionaires, bankers, government ministers - lots of decision makers. Lots of information.

"Oh my God..." said Finn, scrolling back a few lines. He showed the email to Adam who let out a low whistle.

"Well that's a surprise. Someone has been keeping pretty quiet about that."

Finn clicked a few times on the screen and pulled up a whole thread of emails. A conversation going back months, years even.

Laid out in front of them Adam and Finn could see a long exchange of emails between Robert Fallon and Lorraine Lucas. Lorraine Lucas, of course, was born Lorraine Mundy and recently married to become Lorraine Metcalf.

"Why would she keep it a secret that she knew him?" Adam asked.

"Money," said Finn without looking up. "Actually, reading between the lines, I don't think they've ever met. It looks like Lorraine's late husband created some Bitcoin that, somehow, came into the possession of Fallon. She has been complaining he stole them and wants them back. He claims they were a gift from her husband and it's nothing to do with her."

"So, Lorraine's husband was involved in Bitcoin very early on?" said Adam.

"Yeah, he was a software developer in Silicon Valley through the nineties and early 2000's but got involved in cryptocurrency almost as a hobby. He was well off just because he had shares in some small start up companies... like Google in '96 but not as rich as she thought he should be."

"So that ties in with..."

"It does indeed Adam."

Finn looked out at the reception area and the lounge. People had started to assemble because they were anticipating yet another round of police interviews. Some had been to lunch, some had been in the garden but there seemed to have been an unspoken signal to gather them all together.

There was a feeling of fatigue setting in among the guests and staff. As if, the news should move on to the next story. In a world of 'News 24' they felt the story had been covered enough and there should be something else to occupy their limited attention span.

"Something is going on," Finn said. "Let's go and join them and see what happens."

They sat down with James and Anna as James let out a long sigh. "I feel like confessing myself just so we can all go home," he said.

"Well, we could all go home at least. I think you might be here longer," Adam laughed.

From the corner of his eye Finn saw Inspector Coates and Sergeant Cross arrive at reception. He watched as uniformed officers followed them in and spread out around the area.

"They're covering the exits," he whispered to Adam.

"Ladies and gentlemen" announced Coates. There was an air of the theatrical about him and Adam would put good money on him being a member of an amateur dramatics group. An enthusiastic, but not very good, amateur dramatics group.

"We have recovered what we firmly believe to be the murder weapon from the lake and matched DNA from the handle"

"How can you have DNA if it's been underwater?" Simon Metcalf blurted out.

Inspector Coates gave a small smile. This was his Colombo moment. His 'Inspector Griffin Investigates' moment. The fact that the grandson of Inspector Griffin's creator was there made it all the more special.

Simon watched the inspector smile. He took a sharp breath but he was calm. He knew that the water would have destroyed any DNA. He'd definitely seen that on TV. They were bluffing, looking for a reaction.

"Some surfaces will retain DNA even with total immersion Mr Metcalf," he told Simon. "The time period is critical and the material. In this case the hammer was recovered less than 24 hours after immersion and the handle of the hammer is hickory. Hardwood is the perfect medium."

There was a moment, a barely perceptible beat while that information sunk in.

"The DNA we recovered from the murder weapon has been identified from our records as one Philip Clarke." Coates paused, "and Philip Clarke, as you will know Mr Metcalf... is you."

There was a moment when Simon looked like he might make a run for it. A quick glance around at the uniformed police officers told him otherwise.

"Philip Clarke, I am arresting you on suspicion of the murder of Lewis Kelly." Bill Cross took over from his boss. "You do not have to say anything..."

This time he had barely started the standard caution when there was a scream.

Lorraine Metcalf burst into tears. Suddenly she was a believable actress.

"This explains so much. He arrived back at our room in a very agitated state and threatened me with violence if I didn't confirm his story." she sobbed.

"And last night..." she pulled a plastic bag out of her handbag "... he gave me this!"

"That's my husband's watch," gasped Louise.

Simon turned on Lorraine. "She made me do it!" he shouted. "I didn't even know that man but she told me he had stolen money and that watch from her father. He said he had raped her when she was sixteen. She said..." his voice tailed off.

He slowly realised the conman had been played. He had been so caught up in the need to distance himself from the death of Lewis Kelly that he'd been manipulated by his wife.

If the killing of Lewis Kelly had been a split second of panic and impulse; the murder of Robert Fallon was planned in detail... but not by Simon Metcalf. It was fully formed right down to the fall-guy who would take the blame. Simon Metcalf knew that he'd been set up. He didn't understand why, but he knew there was no way out for him.

Chapter Eighteen

Finn was still tapping away on his lap and Adam looked over his shoulder.

"No big surprise there. First Class flight too. I think we'd better step in, don't you think?" Adam said.

Finn nodded.

Adam stood as Sergeant Cross had finished the arrest of Simon Metcalf.

"Inspector..." he called out, "we have some other evidence that you might discover too late but it is hugely relevant to this case."

The room went quiet. Everyone looked in Adam's direction as he and Finn moved into the main lounge area.

"The two murders are connected but not in the way you think. That will become clear to you, but too late to catch all the guilty parties."

The two police officers exchanged a glance and Inspector Coates gestured to Adam to continue.

"At first glance, Simon Metcalf is a conman who specialises in wealthy widows. You were able to trace his DNA because he recently spent time in prison for fraud."

"We can't prove it but I'd guess that Simon and Lewis Kelly were cell-mates at some point." Finn added.

"So... Simon goes out for a cigarette and finds Lewis Kelly lurking in the shadows." Adam points at Emily. "Stalking Emily because he had been released by the police by mistake."

Some of the onlookers seemed confused so Finn chipped in again "Kelly was sent to prison for nearly beating Emily to death and then kidnapped her as soon as he was released."

"But other than Fallon witnessing the murder, and there is no sign of that," Adam continued, "there's nothing to link him and Simon Metcalf."

"I think 'she made me do it' is an interesting start to a confession Mr Griffin" said Inspector Coates.

"Maybe, but was he alone?"

Adam looked round the room. He felt slightly guilty for laughing at Alan Coates' amateur dramatics because that was exactly what he was doing now. Well...he thought, they came for a murder mystery weekend, just not a real one.

"The key to all this, as it often is, would be to 'follow the money'" Finn joined in.

"Yes indeed," said Adam "because Simon Metcalf has no link to Robert Fallon... but Lorraine Metcalf does."

There was gasp across the room from Simon. Nothing was clear yet but suddenly there was light.

"That's ridiculous, I've never met the man."

"That's right. You have never met him but he was friendly with your late husband about fifteen years ago wasn't he?" Adam looked straight at Lorraine daring her to deny it. She stayed silent.

"And for the past year or more you have been exchanging email messages with Fallon demanding the return of some of your husband's property that you claim he stole."

"The whole seance nonsense was just a way of manipulating Simon." Finn said "You thought, by telling him that a spirit had told you about his plan to steal your money, that you could talk him into killing Fallon. Stop him going to prison again and living happily ever after."

"What you didn't know was that he had already killed Kelly and was racked with guilt. That guilt and, in his mind, the promise of a cast iron alibi made him agree to anything. Even another murder."

Adam was slipping into an area where he was filling in details that seemed logical but he couldn't confirm. He knew that but he was confident that one or both would crack and confess.

"Ridiculous..." snorted Lorraine. "I was threatened by him, coerced into lying but I never knew about Kelly until just now."

"Are you saying that Mrs Metcalf had her husband kill Robert Fallon over a pocket watch that she thinks he stole fifteen years ago?" Inspector Coates asked.

Adam looked at Finn and raised an eyebrow as if to say 'go ahead'.

"No Inspector, that's what we're supposed to think but as we all have discovered Robert Fallon was a very vain and proud man. He was an early adopter of Facebook and posted a photo of that watch, attached to his waistcoat, in 2008, at least two years before he met Lorraine's husband Gerry."

"Incidentally," Adam slipped in. "It's a 1905 Patek Philippe rose gold pocket watch probably worth six to ten thousand pounds."

Bill Cross raised his eyebrows and let out a long breath through his partially closed lips. It was a louder sound than he'd intended. Adam acknowledged it with a small nod.

"So basically he was showing off his wealth and his good taste. In fact, he did it again in 2015. Similar photo, boasting of his antique watch '105 years old and keeping perfect time' he wrote."

"But this time," said Finn. "There's a difference. In 2015, you can clearly see a small USB drive attached to his watch chain. Just like you can see in that plastic bag that Mrs Metcalf just produced."

Finn and Adam both looked at Lorraine. There was just the faintest glimmer of a smirk on her face. Not worried, not concerned.

"So, why commit murder over a six thousand pound watch?" said Adam. "Sentimental value? Well, no, because we already know that Fallon already owned the watch. So... something else? But don't forget, follow the money."

"It wasn't the watch at all, it was the USB drive." Finn said.

"Whatever was on that drive was worth killing someone for."

"The drive is just there" Lorraine exclaimed "just check it and you'll see this is all nonsense. Simon killed Fallon to silence a witness and he just took the watch because he's a greedy fool."

"There's something you aren't saying, isn't there?" Bill Cross asked.

"You're right, Sergeant Cross," said Finn with a smile. That drive is almost certainly empty but it's a generic thing. I could buy the exact one online right now for less than a fiver - exactly the same. But when Lorraine came downstairs to reception last night I just knew something was fishy."

Lorraine was beginning to look restless. She was trying to think of reasons for her visit.

"I was just posting a surprise present for my husband... some cuff-links. I didn't want him to find them in our room and spoil the surprise"

"You bought your husband a present even though he'd just threatened you with violence? Adam asked.

Lorraine was silent.

"No," Finn said. "What Lorraine was doing was removing the USB drive that she had made Simon steal, although Simon thought it was the watch, and switching it for a duplicate."

Lorraine had actually seen the package behind reception that morning. It hadn't dawned on her that the body might be discovered so early so she thought the courier would arrive before 9am as arranged. Before the police arrived. She quickly revised her plan and decided she would collect the package herself from reception when the police took Simon away and she was released.

She would tell that nice young man at reception that 'under the circumstances' she didn't want to give her husband a surprise present.

But, was this all unravelling? Those two amateur detectives were ruining her timeline... and her escape plan.

"So she posted a package containing the original USB drive?" Inspector Coates demanded, sounding frustrated. "What's on the USB drive?"

"No, the package is still on reception because the police arrived earlier than she expected and the courier was turned away this morning." Again, Adam was filling in some gaps but it seemed to follow a logical sequence.

"So we can get the package from reception and check the drive?"

"Ahh... no." said Finn sheepishly.

Lorraine looked up sharply.

"What is in the package is a different USB drive with a small text file saying 'Finn was here'."

Finn delved into his laptop bag and produced a small pair of tweezers holding the USB drive in its plastic bag.

"Tweezers?" said Adam quietly.

"Two different sizes. Always prepared!" Finn grinned.

"This is the original drive. I haven't touched either the drive or the bag so you might find evidence of Mr Fallon or one of the Metcalfs."

"That's my property," spat Lorraine. "You have no right..."

"But..." Inspector Coates said, cutting her off. "You know what is on the drive don't you Mr Williams?"

"I do, and that is where 'follow the money' becomes important." Finn replied but gestured towards Adam who took up the story.

"Gerry Lucas was a successful software engineer from the early 90's until his death. He became a significant developer involved in the creation of Bitcoin."

Adam saw Anthony Shannon sit upright as if the previous revelations were boring but now he was interested.

"Now we don't know why but for some reason Gerry Lucas gave Robert Fallon some early Bitcoin. If you check Fallon's online email account you will see a long, long exchange where Lorraine Lucas, Gerry's widow, is claiming that Fallon stole them and demanding he return them. Fallon consistently refused saying they had been either a gift or payment for some sort of service."

"So you're saying Robert Fallon was murdered for this... Bitcoin thing," Bill Cross asked. He clearly didn't understand the concept of cryptocurrency, along with a very significant portion of the population.

"Bitcoin was one of the first cryptocurrencies" said Anthony Shannon. "It was originally an attempt to create a monetary system outside of the giant banks and governments. I know the name Gerry Lucas but he was working when two pizzas cost ten thousand Bitcoin."

"Absolutely correct, but Bitcoin has increased in value immensely thanks to a mixture of hype and black-money" Finn said.

"How much money nowadays?" Coates asked.

"A single Bitcoin today is worth around \$82,000... maybe £60,000" said Shannon.

"And that USB drive contains a lot of money?" Bill Cross was looking and sounding sceptical.

"No, not really." Finn told him. "Think of it like a key to a vault. You plug the key in and get access to whatever is inside. The vault is actually online in a server somewhere.

"But here's the irony... and the stupidity," Adam interjected. "Fallon really did get the Bitcoin as a gift from Gerry Lucas. Very early on he created a draft email to Lorraine with an attached photo of a handwritten note from Gerry confirming it all. Sadly, Fallon was such a twisted and unpleasant man he decided not to send the proof and just let Lorraine continue with her demands. He wanted her to suffer a bit more for his own entertainment."

"He enjoyed the sense of power over Lorraine, knowing that, even if it went to court he could produce his evidence." Finn said. "But he preferred to let Lorraine squirm and that is what got him killed."

"It was my money. I created that with my husband. He had no right to take it." Lorraine shouted.

"But he did Lorraine. Your husband gave him the money. The note actually says it's 'only worth a thousand dollars but who knows in the future.'"

"Wait..." said Shannon. "A thousand dollars in Bitcoin in 2010?"

"I know," said Finn. "And what is more amazing is that this USB drive has no password, no encryption, no security."

"So how many of these Bitcoins are on there?" asked Cross, still struggling with the basic contents.

"It's just a key to the vault but whoever has the key has access to a completely untraceable fortune. Eight thousand Bitcoin." Finn told him.

"WHAT?" Shannon shouted, jumping to his feet. "That's..." he struggled to do the maths in his head.

"Just short of £500 million" Finn answered.

"And the reason it's important at this precise moment Inspector, is that, if you check her phone, Lorraine Metcalf is checked in online for a first class, one way, ticket to Dubai. I don't doubt she has a new identity waiting for her there and will disappear. Or stay there, Dubai is notoriously difficult to get extradition from."

"Bill..." Coates spoke to Sergeant Cross and nodded towards Lorraine Metcalf.

As Cross started to arrest Lorraine for Conspiracy to Murder, Coates walked over to Finn and Adam.

"You know you've messed up the chain of evidence for the USB drive don't you. I could arrest the pair of you."

"You could" said Finn brightly, "but then you'd have a lot of explaining to do about how one of the conspirators would have disappeared without trace. Also, in court, a lot of sensitive Government information would need to come out about ex-MI5 hackers, the Prime Minister's son would have to give evidence, maybe even the Prime Minister herself..."

"Enough..." said Coates, holding up his hand. "I won't say thank you, but you did a good job."

"To be honest I think Simon will squeal like a piggy now he knows she intended to let him take the fall." Adam said. "You might not get them on the attempted theft but you've got both murders cleared up."

"One thing I don't understand," said Coates. "How did you get the package, and why?"

"The how is easy, I just waited till the receptionist went into the back office and I stole the package from behind the desk" Finn smiled as he stretched the truth to cover for Alfie.

"So, one count of theft" Coates counted off on his fingers.

"As to why... just a hunch really. It was all so odd. Odd timing. Odd body language. She couldn't see me because I was working behind a pillar and some plants but I could see her scanning round furtively. It just rang alarm bells."

Finn went on to explain that, as soon as he had seen the USB drive in the bag, he knew it was from Fallon. He didn't know Fallon was dead at that time but when he saw the contents he knew there was something very wrong.

"I'll need the USB drive as evidence" Coates told them.

"But you know it legally belongs to Mrs Fallon now?" Finn told him.

"And it will be returned to her at the proper time" Coates said, a little pompously.

Finn used his tweezers and dropped the drive into an evidence bag. They watched as Coates went around ensuring everything was

officially completed.

Then he announced that everyone would be required to make formal statements but, for now, they were all free to leave.

Finn joined Anna, James and Emily on some sofas while Adam rang to arrange some transport home.

"Don't ever say I never invite you anywhere exciting," said James.

"I'm just glad to be off the hook." Emily huffed out a loud breath.

"You were never on the hook Em, it just took a little while to prove it."

Alice Cooper appeared in the lounge as Adam got off the phone.

"My work is done," the lawyer announced. "Although in fairness there wasn't a lot for me to do."

"Please send me your bill for all of us," Adam told her.

"There's no bill," she told him. "I wouldn't be here, wouldn't have the life I live, if it wasn't for Finn's Dad so..."

Adam met her eyes. He allowed silence to fill the space between them, waiting for Alice to give more details.

"Maybe I'll tell you when I know you better," she said, holding out her hand.

Adam shook her hand and they both smiled.

"So... we're all going home." Adam winked at her. "School's out?"

Alice sighed. "That's an Alice Cooper song isn't it?"

Adam beamed. "I looked it up specially for this moment"

Alice closed her eyes and silently shook her head. "Welcome to my nightmare," she said.

Adam laughed. "I know what you did there. But seriously, if we can do anything for you, please don't hesitate to ask."

Their transport arrived quite quickly so within an hour they were packed up and ready to go.

As their luxury van pulled into the driveway James' phone rang.

"Oh-oh..." he said ominously "If it's not one thing, it's your Mother."

"She's going to kill you for not telling her," Anna told him as he peeled away to answer the call.

As the driver was loading their luggage Adam looked sideways at Finn by his side.

"You're like a dog with two tails," he said.

"Yup." Finn smiled.

"You've done something haven't you?"

"Yup."

"You've made a copy of the USB drive haven't you?"

"Yup."

"Is it for Louise?"

"Yup."

"What else?"

"Both copies are now encrypted up to the eyeballs. It would even take the CIA a month of Sundays to open it up."

"So... the police...?"

"Can't access anything without a 37 digit random password."

"So they will just pass it back to Louise as part of Fallon's belongings?"

"That's my guess."

"And the password?"

Finn tapped the side of his head.

"Thirty seven digits?"

"There's got to be some benefits to being this clever," Finn laughed.

EPILOGUE

From their new apartment it was a few steps for Finn and Adam to turn down Queens Passage. It's a narrow alleyway barely three feet wide that leads straight into Green Park. If you didn't know it, you might assume it was the path to someone's garden.

As they walked through the park they stayed close, often bumping shoulders, laughing and talking in low voices. They had been invited to afternoon tea with Robby.

"Why have we been invited to tea?" Finn asked.

"I have no idea," Adam replied. "Robby was very specific and seemed terribly excited. He does love a bit of intrigue."

It was six months since their Murder Mystery Weekend turned into a real life murder mystery. The Metcalfs had both been charged and remanded in custody pending trial. Simon Metcalf had decided to plead guilty and give evidence against his wife. Lorraine had continued to plead not guilty and claim her husband had coerced her. She was also claiming to have no knowledge of the amount of money they had taken from Robert Fallon.

If asked privately, Lorraine's legal team weren't optimistic.

The sun was shining and there were thousands of tourists enjoying the late summer sun, but somehow they felt like the world was just a distant place - outside of their bubble of happiness.

Emily had decided she needed to step back from her life of adventure. She started an Open University degree and accepted a full time job. As Housekeeper to Adam and Finn.

She had been a tough negotiator. "I don't clean," she told them, "but I will supervise the cleaners. I'm more of an organiser so I'll arrange for cleaners, caterers, gardeners and whatever else you need."

Her aunt Lizzie was delighted, having been Adam's grandmother's housekeeper most of her life. She told Emily that she might find she never wanted to leave - just like Lizzie had discovered herself all those years ago.

Adam and Finn had arranged for the small apartment in the roof garden to be completely refurbished first so she had moved in before them. The builders and decorators that were working on the apartment all called her Sybil Fawltly because she was merciless with them. She chivvied and berated them, asked questions and accepted no nonsense. Then she would arrange pizzas for Friday lunch and let everyone go early to avoid the worst of the rush hour.

The whole construction crew loved her... but nobody called her Sybil to her face.

When Adam and Finn finally moved in, the apartment was spotless. Furniture had been delivered on time, kitchen appliances were all working and it immediately felt like home.

They had converted a bedroom into an office and Finn had moved his entire computer setup over the course of a weekend. The library had been mainly redecorated and now contained a huge sofa and an equally large TV. They had decided that this was their favourite room, mainly because they could cuddle on the sofa and watch films on the giant screen.

Robby had visited and thoroughly approved.

As they skirted around the Queen Victoria Monument outside the Palace, tourists were dicing with death, as if they came from a land with no traffic. The boys laughed wondering how bad it must be during the changing of the guard but it was a good natured stroll through the crowds.

As they walked alongside the high walls of the palace gardens they turned into a quiet road and came to a hotel. The uniformed doorman smiled and opened the door for them.

"I believe His Grace is already in the garden gentlemen," he said quietly. Even a discerning and refined hotel like this had extra layers of discretion.

The hotel had been in the same family for over a hundred years. It was the haunt of royalty, the aristocracy, the great and the good and the discreetly wealthy.

"Have you been here before?" Finn asked.

"Many times, it's one of Robby's favourite places. It was mainly when I was a kid - complete waste of a good afternoon tea," Adam grinned.

Walking across the lobby area to the garden they could see Robby sitting alone at the far end of the lawn.

Adam kissed him on both cheeks before he said,

"I didn't know they let people eat on the grass."

"They don't," said Robby simply before hugging Finn and kissing him twice.

"A table for six Robby? What are you up to?" Adam asked although he knew Robby wouldn't let out his secret surprise. Robby just tapped the side of his nose.

As they sat a waiter started to bring tea, cakes and tiny sandwiches.

"Ah, here they are!" Robby exclaimed and, when Finn and Adam looked up they were surprised to see Louise Fallon on the arm of Giles walking towards them. Louise was walking normally and had no crutches. Both her and Giles had a completely different air about them. More confident, more buoyant. In one word, they both looked happy.

"I invited Louise and Giles because I believe Finn and Giles have some unfinished business and Louise and I want to press-gang Adam into something new and exciting," Robby told them.

There was polite conversation initially. Louise recounted how she'd had both hips replaced in a private hospital, then spent six weeks in

the Italian lakes to recuperate. Apart from the cryptocurrency there was plenty of money available and Louise had kept Giles on as her assistant for the time being.

While she was in Italy Giles had been in charge of finding her a London home and sorting through her husband's papers. It was Giles who found the original document confirming the legitimacy of the Bitcoin gift Fallon had received.

When Louise returned from Italy she'd received a phone call from Robby. He had introduced her to, what he described as, some 'relatively honest bankers' and Louise had decided to sell everything and start a more traditional investment portfolio.

After a short while Finn motioned Giles to one side.

"All of those images are gone Giles. All of them! Fallon had exchanged similar photos with two other people so I accessed their computers and deleted your images. While I was there both men had... very unpleasant and illegal images on their systems so I anonymously reported them to the police and I know it's been followed up."

"And there's no comeback on you?" Giles asked.

"None at all. One of the men is a politician so I anonymously messaged the Prime Minister to tip her off. No chance of a slimeball escaping now."

"How do you message the Prime Minister?" Giles said but Finn just smiled.

"Thank you Finn. Really, I can't thank you enough." he paused
"Louise has been so kind to me. She's given me £10 million Finn! Me!"

"Wow, that's amazing." Finn really was amazed.

"It's got some strings. I've bought a nice two bedroom flat just off Sloane Square with a little roof terrace and the rest is in trust so I don't waste it all, or get swindled."

"That sounds like a perfect solution Giles."

As Finn spoke a familiar figure strode across the lawn. "I have a new job," he said excitedly.

"ALFIE!" Adam and Finn spoke together.

"Sit down dear boy, I knew you had it in you," said Robby.

To Adam's surprise Alfie gave Robby a peck on the cheek and then sat down close to Giles.

Although perhaps it wasn't a surprise. It was very Robby.

"I'm so pleased for you," said Giles as he took Alfie's hand.

"Wait... are you two..." Finn stammered. Both Giles and Alfie blushed a little.

"Well, yes," said Alfie. "After that weekend we started messaging and then we met up in London. My job at the hotel was getting difficult because the General Manager seemed to think I had murdered both those people so Robby kindly got me an interview here."

Robby made a dismissive gesture. "Nonsense Alfie, you got the job on your own merit." He turned to Adam "I had met Louise, then Giles and then inevitably Alfie. All I did was to suggest he might fit in well here."

"But a reference from Robby didn't harm things" said Alfie happily. "I was even given permission to have afternoon tea before I start work."

"Now, over to you Adam." Robby said "You might recall that I am the Patron of a charity helping young homeless people in London. It's not specific, but most of them are LGBT young people. The world can be very cruel."

Adam nodded, he'd heard Robby talk of this place before.

"Louise has very kindly agreed to become a donor... a substantial donor," Robby's eyes flashed with mischief. "But I am getting on a

bit so I would like you to take over as Patron and Chairman of the Trustees."

Robby and Louise looked at Adam expectantly.

"Do you expect an answer now?" Adam asked

"Yes, of course they do," said Finn. "Or no cake for you."

"What's involved?" Adam asked.

"Some boring meetings and a bit of your money. Just say yes and trust Robby," Finn told him.

"How do you know so much about it? Adam asked him.

"Well..." Finn gestured towards Robby, "obviously some clandestine conspiracy was involved but I think Robby had already decided you were up for it."

Adam threw up a hand in surrender. "OK, you're on, as long as Finn has to come to all the boring meetings!!"

There were muted cheers around the table, with all the decorum the hotel deserved.

The rest of their afternoon tea was a happy success. When Adam and Finn got home there was a ping on Adam's phone. It was a video message from Robby. It started bizarrely with the Mission Impossible music before Robby appeared on the screen.

"Hello to my two favourite people" he said "As you might see I am in what will become your home and I wanted to share a little secret with you." Robby looked really happy because nothing made him happier than devilry and intrigue.

Robby was sending the video from the library but it was while he still lived there himself. "I wanted to wait until you had done all the renovation work and made it your own. I also wanted to see if your builders rumbled my little plan. But apparently not."

Robby turned the phone to the rear camera so they could see what he was looking at.

"I know Finn does some confidential work, some might even say top secret, so I thought you both might appreciate this"

Robby reached into the back of the bookcase, around waist height and there was an audible click.

"Try it yourselves. Now three people know the secret and when I'm gone... just you two."

Robby clicked off and the screen went blank.

"What the..." Adam looked from his phone to the bookcase and then back to Finn.

As they approached the place Robby had been standing Adam reached under the shelf.

"There's nothing," he told Finn.

"There must be something. Run your finger along the back," Finn suggested.

Adam did as Finn advised and his eyes lit up. "It's like a button... barely noticeable" he whispered.

There was a click, like the video, and a gentle push from Adam made the bookcase swing silently backwards. They both gasped.

"It's like a secret room," said Finn.

As they walked into the space behind the bookcase they could see a narrow room stretching the length of the library but only about six feet wide. There was a small desk with a chair on either side and, high up on the far wall, an air conditioning unit hummed quietly as it kept the room cool.

Finn pushed the door back into the main bookcase and there were three large bolts that slid easily into place, making it very secure. He swung it back open and it clicked perfectly into place against the side wall.

"Clever..." he told Adam. "With the door pushed open it looks like a slightly weird room layout for the library..."

"Which means you could get someone in to install air conditioning without revealing that it's a hidden room." Adam finished for him.

Adam's phone pinged again. Another video message.

"Are you in yet my darlings?" Robby looked very pleased with himself. "When I got the wonderful Ted to install this, my first thought was just storage space. Then it occurred to me that it was really somewhere between a panic room and a quiet place."

"As you may have realised..." Robby continued "I have had cause to hide from angry wives in the past, but also deranged Latino lovers. The backs of the bookcases are two hundred year old walnut about two inches thick. Even an enraged Cuban with an axe wouldn't get through that very quickly."

Adam and Finn laughed out loud before Robby continued "That has never happened though, obviously... although I did get chased through the park by the very angry wife of a government minister with a riding crop once. It was about her son, not her husband thank God. Her husband was a loathsome toad of a man."

Robby had the knack of telling the most outrageous stories in such a matter of fact way. As if everyone had once been chased by the mother of a lover, who planned to horse whip him.

"Happy days. I miss the swinging sixties," Robby laughed impishly.

As the video ended Finn shook his head. "I knew something was off here but I just couldn't figure it out. My brain wasn't quite computing the measurements of the two rooms."

"You're not alone," Adam told him. "Apparently it outwitted a mad Cuban axeman too."

"Old Ted was a wonderful craftsman but let's hope we never need to have a panic room," Finn said.

Adam took Finn's hand and smiled. "To be honest, I don't think there's anything we couldn't take on, as long as we're together."

Finn pulled Adam into a hug. "And I know we'll always be together."

